

Vox



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF CHRISTINA DALCHER

Christina Dalcher was raised in New Jersey. She attended Georgetown University and received a PhD in linguistics. Later, Dalcher moved to London to research at City University, London. There, she studied how speakers of different British dialects learned, heard, and produced the r sound. After living in London, Dalcher taught linguistics, academic writing, phonetics, beginning Italian, and other related classes at a variety of British and American universities, as well as at a university in Abu Dhabi. Dalcher had been writing and publishing flash fiction (short stories shorter than 1500 words) for some time when, in 2017, she decided to expand one of her stories into what would become *Vox*. She wrote *Vox* in about two months. Following *Vox*, Dalcher has written several other novels that explore similar themes. She lives in Virginia with her husband.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

While *Vox* never names names, it very clearly alludes to Donald Trump's time as president, and President Myers is a fictional analogue for former President Trump. Specifically, the novel draws on Trump's successful overtures toward evangelical Christians in the leadup to the 2016 election. Analysts have noted that while Trump himself doesn't adhere to conventional Christian values or lifestyle choices—he's been married three times, is known for infidelity, and has been accused of sexual assault—evangelical Christians overwhelmingly voted for him in 2016 due to his promises to appoint justices to the federal judiciary and the Supreme Court who would be hostile to protecting or expanding abortion rights. Wernicke's aphasia, also known as receptive aphasia, is a condition that occurs most commonly in people who have suffered strokes, though it can also happen to people who develop brain tumors in Wernicke's area of the brain or who suffer traumatic brain injuries. Those afflicted struggle to understand written and spoken language, and their speech is totally unintelligible—and they often don't realize their speech is impossible to understand. Treatment varies from case to case, but nearly always includes speech-language therapy to help patients learn to successfully express themselves. There is, however, no cure.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

The most obvious related work to *Vox* is, of course, Margaret Atwood's classic novel [The Handmaid's Tale](#), which also sees women subjugated in an alternate United States where a

religious faction has taken over the government. Within the book itself, Jean makes references to Aldous Huxley's [Brave New World](#), Anthony Burgess's [A Clockwork Orange](#), and George Orwell's [1984](#), as well as children's classics like A. A. Milne's Winnie the Pooh stories. Dalcher also lists Ray Bradbury's [Fahrenheit 451](#) as an influence more generally, in addition to Ira Levin's novel [The Stepford Wives](#), Stephen King's horror novels (*Carrie*; [It](#)), and the work of children's author Roald Dahl ([Matilda](#); [Charlie and the Chocolate Factory](#)). Published in 2018, midway through former President Trump's term in office, *Vox* was released alongside several other novels that drew some inspiration from or connections with [The Handmaid's Tale](#) and that seemed to respond specifically to the push in American politics to curtail women's rights. These include Naomi Alderman's [The Power](#), *Red Clocks* by Leni Zumas, and [Future Home of the Living God](#) by Louise Erdrich. Since *Vox*, Dalcher has published several other novels that explore similar themes, including *Master Class* and *Femlandia*.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** *Vox*
- **When Written:** 2017
- **Where Written:** United States
- **When Published:** 2018
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Dystopian Novel, Speculative Fiction
- **Setting:** Washington, D.C., in an alternate late-2010s reality
- **Climax:** Jean shoots and kills Morgan.
- **Antagonist:** Supporters of the Pure movement; Morgan, President Myers, and other powerful men in government
- **Point of View:** First Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Spread the Word. Dalcher, who studied linguistics before becoming an author, offers many of her scientific papers, presentations, and lecture notes on her website for curious readers.



PLOT SUMMARY

Throughout her adult life, Dr. Jean McClellan has eschewed political protest, and she hasn't always voted. Now a 43-year-old married mother of three sons and one daughter, though, she regrets her previous inaction. This is because a year ago, after President Myers was elected with the help of Reverend Carl Corbin's Pure Movement, the government stripped

women of their jobs and forced all women and girls to wear a **counter**, a device that limits them to speaking 100 words per day—and shocks them if they exceed that limit. Jean is now filled with rage, and she feels like it's too late to do anything to change things. It's especially galling because Jean's husband Patrick is the president's science advisor, and he is, in Jean's estimation, a "weak" man who isn't appropriately using the privilege he has. And Jean's eldest, Steven, has fully bought into the Pure Movement—he's now insufferably superior and sexist. Jean thinks often of her best friend from grad school, Jackie Juarez, who dedicated her life to leading protests for women's rights—Jackie saw this coming, and Jean now regrets not listening to her.

One afternoon, Patrick, Reverend Carl, and several other men come to the McClellan house. The president's brother (and closest advisor), Bobby Myers, has suffered a skiing injury and now suffers from Wernicke's aphasia, a condition Jean was developing a cure for prior to the Pure Movement's takeover that causes a person to speak utter nonsense. Enraged, Jean declines the invitation. However, when Sonia comes home from school, thrilled that she won a prize for not speaking at all at school earlier, Jean decides to negotiate with the government. She asks for her and Sonia's counters to be removed and for Sonia to be excused from school while Jean works. The president agrees.

The next morning, after signing her paperwork, Jean drives to the labs. Her former colleague, Lin, is on the project—as is Lorenzo, Jean's Italian lover. Jean vomits when she runs into Lorenzo and quickly realizes that she's pregnant with Lorenzo's baby (they met up and had sex about two months ago).

The labs and facilities are filled with expensive equipment, as well as mice and rabbits on which to conduct experiments. There's also a terrifying security guard, Poe, who seems to constantly lurk around. That evening, Jean calls Mamma and Papà in Italy from Patrick's office. After the call, Jean can't help herself: she opens a **manila envelope** on Patrick's desk labeled "top secret." It details that there are three times, White, Gold, and Red, on "Project Wernicke."

That night, police sirens wake Jean and her family up: the police have come for Julia King, their next-door neighbors' daughter and Steven's crush. She and Steven had premarital sex, and Steven reported her. The next morning, Papà calls with the news that Mamma had a brain aneurysm and is now suffering from Wernicke's aphasia.

Jean's mailman, Del Ray, is both seemingly sympathetic to women's current plight and the son of Delilah Ray, an elderly stroke victim who was to be Jean's first human test subject for her anti-aphasia serum. Jean speaks with Del and arranges for Sonia to spend the day with his wife and for Mrs. Ray to come into the lab for an injection. At the Rays' farm, Jean discovers that Del and Sharon are running a resistance operation: Del has discovered how to remove counters and has replaced his wife

and daughters' counters with fakes. Sharon, who's Black, insists it's only a matter of time before the Pure Movement begins targeting people of color and anyone in an interracial marriage. Jean then attends her first prenatal appointment, where the doctor confirms that she's 10 weeks pregnant.

At work, Jean tells Lorenzo about her pregnancy, and she begins to snoop around for signs of what Project Wernicke might actually be. Feigning illness, Jean goes home early and, to her horror, gets home just as Olivia King, Julia's mother, is being loaded into an ambulance, her left hand and wrist little more than a charred stump. Patrick shares that Olivia recorded "I'm sorry, Julia" on a Dictaphone and set it to repeat. Steven is also distraught: at school, his teacher showed Julia's televised shaming and then forced students to write letters to her using numerous slurs and insults. Steven did it, but he implies that he's no longer committed to the Pure Movement after seeing what happened to Julia.

That night, Jean sneaks into Patrick's office and flips through the top-secret envelope. She discovers that while her team is supposed to develop an anti-Wernicke serum, the other teams will reverse-engineer it and then make it water soluble, thereby enabling the government to poison water supplies. In the morning, she and Patrick discover that Steven ran away to try to rescue Julia—and Poe arrests Del, whom Jean realizes is a messenger for the resistance, while he's picking up the manila envelope from Jean's mailbox. Jean continues on to work, pretending things are normal. Concerningly, Lin isn't at work. Jean and Lorenzo perform an experiment on mice and, while they wait for their results, drive to the cottage where they've conducted their affair for the last couple years. Lorenzo presents Jean with his deceased wife's passport, and Jean agrees to leave the country with him if the baby is a girl; she has a test to determine the baby's sex in a few days.

After work, Patrick comes clean with Jean: he's working with the resistance and he expects to be arrested and executed soon. He insists she needs to leave the country with Lorenzo and Sonia, and they work through the night to figure out a formula for a serum Patrick could use to poison the president, Reverend Carl, and other high-ranking officials at their next meeting on Monday morning.

Jean goes to work the next day, Saturday. Today is Mrs. Ray's trial—and the serum works perfectly. Following this success, Poe kicks Jean and Lorenzo out of the lab. Before they can leave the parking lot, Morgan calls Jean and Lorenzo back inside to resume work, this time to develop a serum to induce aphasia. The Gold Team's facilities are even better equipped—they have primate test subjects. Morgan has also imprisoned Jackie, Lin, and Lin's former fiancée, Isabel, in a room off the lab. He threatens to have them executed if Jean and Lorenzo don't cooperate, and he makes all the scientists stay overnight to continue their work. It must be done by the Project Wernicke meeting scheduled for Monday morning.

Jean has spent the last few days developing a relationship with Petroski, a young security guard. He has a one-year-old daughter, and when Jean tells him that his daughter will never be functional or well if she never learns to talk, he agrees to help her and Lorenzo. They've decided to test the aphasia-inducing serum, first on a chimp (to make sure it's not fatal) and then on Morgan, their much-hated boss. Petroski helps incapacitate Morgan and breaks Lin free so she can perform the procedure on the chimp. Morgan, however, wakes up before they can perform the procedure on him. With Jackie and Petroski's help, Jean shoots and kills Morgan, and Poe helps get everyone out of the lab safely—it turns out he's working for the resistance.

Since Patrick's cover still hasn't been blown, he goes to the Project Wernicke meeting on Monday morning, where he plans to spike the water and coffee with the deadly serum. He's successful in killing the 12 top government officials, though a rooftop sniper shoots and kills him. Jean arranges for him to be buried at the Rays' farm, and then she, Lorenzo, and her children escape to Italy by way of Canada. Jean plans to return to the now-recovering United States and run for office sometime in the next couple years.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Dr. Jean McClellan – Jean, a 43-year-old cognitive linguist and mother of four, is the novel's protagonist. Throughout her life, Jean has been happy to go with the flow and focus on her family and her research into Wernicke's aphasia, not paying much attention to politics. This led to the end of her friendship with Jackie around the same time as Jean married Patrick. However, in the novel's present, Jean regrets her previous actions, as she believes her (and others') complacency led to the Pure Movement's takeover. As Jean is lured back to work to finish developing her cure for Wernicke's aphasia, she finds herself pulled in multiple directions and having to make impossibly difficult choices. She's been conducting an affair with Lorenzo for several years, and she discovers that they conceived a baby—and she believes she must leave the country if the baby is female. But she also feels like an awful mother for prioritizing her possible daughter and Sonia, her six-year-old, over her three sons. Ultimately, after formulating a cure for aphasia and then reverse-engineering it, Jean helps bring down the Pure Movement and the government. She escapes to Italy with her children and Lorenzo, a widow after a sniper kills Patrick in the government takedown. Having reunited with Jackie, Jean plans to return to the U.S. to get involved in politics.

Patrick McClellan – Patrick is Jean's husband. Jean was initially drawn to Patrick because he was kind, safe, and not at all interested in politics. However, in the novel's present, these

qualities lead Jean to resent Patrick and even cheat on him with Lorenzo, whom she finds more action-oriented and willing to stand up for what he believes in. Patrick is President Myers's science advisor, and Jean believes that Patrick isn't doing enough with the power and influence he has to advocate for positive change—and at points, he also seems to suggest that not letting women speak is a good idea. However, Jean ultimately learns that Patrick's seeming complacency is just a front, and he's actually a key member of the resistance movement who passes government information to other members of the resistance. He works together with Jean to formulate a serum capable of incapacitating or killing those in power, and he poisons the president, Reverend Carl, and 10 other high-ranking government officials at a Project Wernicke meeting. Ultimately, however, rooftop snipers shoot and kill Patrick in the takedown.

Sonia McClellan – Sonia is Jean and Patrick's six-year-old daughter. Prior to the Pure Movement's takeover, Sonia was a verbose and bright five-year-old. But in the present, Sonia has acclimatized to the restrictions placed on her and her speech—it's a galvanizing moment for Jean when Sonia comes home from school, thrilled that she won the contest of who can say the fewest words. As part of her negotiations to return to work, Jean negotiates for Sonia's **counter** to be removed and for Sonia to spend her days at the Rays' farm. While Sonia initially struggles to adjust to being able to speak again, within a few days she seems to have recouped any language she might have lost and become comfortable with her own voice.

Steven McClellan – Sixteen-year-old Steven is Jean and Patrick's oldest child. While Jean and Steven used to have a close and loving relationship, Steven is slowly indoctrinated into the Pure Movement when his school begins offering AP Religious Studies for all students. He thinks at first that some of the ideas just make sense—and as time passes, he becomes to genuinely believe that he, as a young man, is entitled to having total control over his female relatives. He's had a crush on his neighbor and classmate, Julia, for some time, and their relationship continues into the present—though Steven is in talks with Evan, Julia's father, about marrying Julia, without consulting Julia herself. The two ultimately have consensual premarital sex, which Steven, in his unthinking loyalty to the Pure Movement, reports Julia for. However, when he sees her taken away and shamed on TV, and when he's forced to write a letter insulting her, Steven becomes disillusioned and runs away to try to rescue her. Poe ultimately rescues Steven.

Jackie Juarez – Jackie was Jean's best friend in grad school, and though she doesn't appear in person for much of the novel, Jean thinks of Jackie often. They stopped talking about 20 years ago, around the time Jean married Patrick, as Jackie couldn't accept Jean's passivity and lack of political engagement. Jackie has always been extremely politically active and protested often for women's rights. She led protests in

college and, in the years between then and the Pure Movement's takeover, wrote a number of books with inflammatory titles warning of a conservative, anti-woman government takeover. Jean recognizes in the present that Jackie was right about everything—she even predicted Reverend Carl's rise to power. Though Jackie, who's a lesbian, was sent to a conversion camp, Jean and Jackie reunite when Morgan has Jackie brought to the lab and threatens to execute her if Jean doesn't cooperate. Once Patrick kills the top government officials and Reverend Carl, Jackie continues her political advocacy and encourages Jean to get involved in politics.

Lorenzo Rossi – Lorenzo is an Italian biochemistry expert who worked with Jean and Lin on a cure for Wernicke's aphasia. He has remained in the United States following the Pure Movement's government takeover, and he agrees to resume his work alongside his female colleagues. He and Jean have been having an affair for a couple of years. Jean prefers Lorenzo to Patrick primarily because, unlike Patrick, Lorenzo is principled, decisive, and willing to take action—he refuses to shake hands with people whose views offend him, for instance, and openly voices his disagreement with the Pure Movement and the government. When he discovers that he and Jean conceived a baby, he throws himself even more fully into his project of getting Jean out of the country using his deceased wife's passport. Using his biochemistry background, Lorenzo is able to formulate a serum that induces aphasia, which Patrick uses to poison President Myers, Reverend Carl, and 10 other top government officials.

Dr. Lin Kwan – Lin was Jean and Lorenzo's coworker in the neurolinguistics department at Georgetown prior to the Pure Movement's takeover. She's a tiny older woman and is extremely intelligent and accomplished: after working for years as a neurosurgeon, she returned to school to get a dual doctorate in linguistics and cognitive science. Jean negotiates to have Lin on the project when she returns to work to finish formulating the anti-Wernicke's aphasia serum. Lin is a valuable addition to the team in part because of her skill and abilities—she's unbothered by having to experiment on animals—but also because of her astute understanding of the political landscape. When the Pure Movement took over, she broke off her engagement to fellow professor Isabel Gerber to protect them both from being sent to conversion camps. Both Lin and Isabel are arrested and held hostage after Lin's first day of work. Though this is supposed to motivate Jean and Lorenzo to cooperate with the government, they eventually break the prisoners free, and Lin helps them finish their work.

Morgan LeBron – Morgan is Jean, Lin, and Lorenzo's much-younger and wholly unqualified boss. He took Lin's position as department chair after women were dismissed from their jobs. In addition to being a generally poor scientist, Morgan is self-important, selfish, and cruel: he implies at one point that he

finds the lab's primate test subjects to be more valuable than human beings. He also regularly speaks fondly about the 1950s and the era's strict gender roles, mostly because he doesn't want to have to accommodate primarily female problems like menstruation or pregnancy, or parents more generally, at work. Though Jean and Lorenzo plan to test their aphasia-inducing serum on Morgan, they're unable to perform the procedure on him before he wakes up from his sedation. Jean shoots and kills him to prevent him from killing Lorenzo with the serum.

Reverend Carl Corbin – One of the novel's antagonists, Reverend Carl is the leader of the Pure Movement, a (fictional) fundamentalist Christian movement that, among other things, upholds strict gender roles and advocates for conversion therapy for gay people. He's been a televangelist for the last 20 years, since Jean was in college, and helped President Myers get elected by promising votes in exchange for Myers implementing the Pure Movement's agenda nationwide. Since the election, he's been one of the president's top advisors, and it's implied that he and Bobby Myers are actually the ones calling all the shots. To those who don't agree with him, like Jean, Reverend Carl's friendly attitude seems laced with menace. Jean finds him absolutely unhinged, as she figures he understands that poisoning the world's water supply with a serum that induces Wernicke's aphasia is going to totally upend modern civilization as they know it. He's killed, along with other high-ranking government officials, when Patrick spikes the water during a Project Wernicke meeting.

Evan King – Evan, his wife Olivia, and daughter Julia are the McClellan's next-door neighbors. They're about 10 years younger than Jean and Patrick and are extremely devout—they supported the Pure Movement long before the government takeover. Evan, however, is the most pious of his family, and he seems to most appreciate the power that the Pure Movement gives him over his wife and daughter. Jean knows, for instance, that he beats Julia, and he does nothing to stop his daughter from being arrested for engaging in premarital sex. However, to Jean's surprise, the King family—Evan included—attends Patrick's funeral.

Olivia King – Olivia is Jean's next-door neighbor. She and her husband, Evan, are extremely religious. Olivia was fully supportive of the Pure Movement, at least before the wrist **counters** went on and limited women to 100 words per day. But while Jean at points suspects that Olivia is still on board with the Pure Movement's aims, Olivia's actions ultimately suggest she's grown fully disillusioned with it: she fights back when police arrest her daughter Julia for having premarital sex, and she then attempts to take her own life by recording "I'm sorry, Julia" on a Dictaphone and setting it to play on repeat. This burns her hand and wrist almost to nothing. To Jean's surprise, the King family attends Patrick's funeral.

Julia King – Julia is Evan and Olivia's teenaged daughter and Steven's crush. Jean remembers her as a free-spirited girl who

was unenthusiastic about her parents' piety and devotion to the Pure Movement. However, since the Pure Movement took over, Julia suffers physical abuse from her father and has almost no power to make any of her own choices. However, she's still romantically interested in Steven—and the two have consensual premarital sex. Steven reports Julia, though, and Julia is arrested and is sent to South Dakota to work as forced labor. She ultimately returns home after Patrick and Jean overthrow the government.

Delilah Ray – Mrs. Ray was the McClellans' gardener prior to her stroke several years ago. She was once full of life and enthusiastic about both mundane things like pie recipes, and bigger concerns like progressive government policies. However, after her stroke, she suffers from Wernicke's aphasia, which means she can speak—but everything she says is nonsense. Mrs. Ray was set to be Jean's first human test subject for a serum to cure the condition prior to the Pure Movement's takeover, and when Jean is brought back to work, Mrs. Ray finally fulfills this role. The cure works: minutes after receiving an injection, Mrs. Ray can speak intelligibly.

Del Ray/The Mailman – Del is the McClellans' mailman and is secretly the messenger for a resistance group that operates out of his and his wife Sharon's farm. He carries secret messages to and from Patrick through the McClellans' mailbox. He's motivated to get involved with the resistance because of Sharon, who's Black, and his three daughters: Sharon believes that it's only a matter of time before the Pure Movement begins targeting Black people more generally, and interracial marriages like her and Del's in particular. A "tinkerer," Del has come up with a tool to remove government-issued **counters** and replace them with fakes he creates. His mother, Delilah Ray, designed the McClellans' garden prior to her stroke, and Del is extremely interested in getting his mother involved in Jean's trials to test a cure for Wernicke's aphasia.

Sharon Ray – Sharon is Del's wife; she's a no-nonsense Black woman. Sharon and Del lead a resistance group from their farm, where they live with their three daughters and an assortment of animals. Sharon is motivated to organize because she believes the Pure Movement isn't going to stop at just subjugating women—she suspects that before long, they'll begin targeting people of color, particularly those in interracial marriages, like Sharon herself. Though Sharon appears to wear a **counter**, the ones that she and her daughters wear are actually fakes that Del developed. For Jean, Sharon functions as a wake-up call, as prior to meeting Sharon, Jean had no idea that Black women might suffer more, or differently, than she and other white women do under the Pure Movement's tyranny.

Anna Myers – Anna Myers is President Myers's wife. A gorgeous blonde woman who once modeled lingerie, Anna has sunk deep into a depression since becoming First Lady, and she is constantly monitored in case she makes a suicide attempt.

She only leaves her heavily surveilled private residence to appear behind her husband at speaking or television engagements—and like all women in the U.S., she wears a wrist **counter** limiting her to 100 words per day.

President Myers – President Myers is the fictional president of the United States. He came to power by collaborating with Reverend Carl Corbin and the Pure Movement: Reverend Carl promised Myers enough votes to win the election, in exchange for getting his preferred policies put in place. In addition to Carl, Myers's brother Bobby also advises him on policy. The president is implied to be a puppet for Carl and Bobby—he merely wants power and is willing to collaborate with whomever he must in order to get it. He's killed at the breakfast meeting when Patrick spikes the water with Jean and Lorenzo's deadly Wernicke's aphasia-inducing serum.

Bobby Myers – Bobby Myers is President Myers's brother and closest advisor. He suffers a skiing accident that induces Wernicke's aphasia, which is the reason Morgan and Reverend Carl give Jean that they need her to return to work on her serum to cure the condition. However, it's unclear if Bobby actually suffered a traumatic brain injury or if the government simply decides to use his injury as a cover story to justify bringing Jean, Lorenzo, and Lin back to work to create a Wernicke's aphasia-inducing serum, which the government plans to use as a biological weapon.

Mr. Poe – Mr. Poe is a hulking security guard who seems to work for Morgan and the government. Jean, Lin, and Lorenzo find him terrifying, given his size and the fact that he can move absolutely silently. However, they ultimately learn that Mr. Poe is an undercover agent working with Del, Sharon, and Patrick for the resistance. He's the only member of the resistance to witness Patrick's death; he brings Patrick's body back to the Ray farm and shares with Jean what happened to him. After learning he's actually an ally, Jean comes to see Mr. Poe—Chris—as a kind and quiet friend.

Sergeant Petroski – Sergeant Petroski is a young soldier assigned to guard the Georgetown University science labs. Petroski studied philosophy in college and only signed up for the military because of the steady pay and benefits it offers—he doesn't fully believe in the Pure Movement. In fact, he worries immensely for his one-year-old daughter and what might happen to her if she's never allowed to learn to talk. It's his fear for his daughter that leads him to become involved in the resistance, helping Jean and Lorenzo evade and even incapacitate Morgan.

Annie Wilson – Annie Wilson was the McClellans' neighbor—until she was arrested for adultery. Prior to the Pure Movement's takeover, she'd been planning to leave her husband. But after losing her job, she suddenly had nowhere to go and no way to support herself on her own. She continued to see her lover, a man in a blue truck, once a week until her arrest.

Jimbo – Jimbo was a colleague of Patrick’s and a member of the resistance. The government had him executed in front of his former coworkers, including Patrick, to make an example out of him. Prior to his death, Jimbo left information for Patrick, which led Patrick to getting involved in the resistance.

Mamma – Jean’s mother lives in southern Italy with Papà and regularly FaceTimes with Jean and her family in the U.S. Soon after Reverend Carl approaches Jean about working on the serum to cure Wernicke’s aphasia, Mamma suffers a stroke and is herself afflicted with Wernicke’s aphasia. At the end of the novel, once Jean, her children, and Lorenzo escape to Italy, Lorenzo has nearly finished formulating a cure for Mamma.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Thomas – Thomas is one of Patrick’s coworkers. He’s cold, cruel, and seems to have fully bought into the Pure Movement, given his willingness to carry out violence on the government’s behalf. He murders Jimbo, and he’s the technician responsible for securing and replacing women’s counters.

Dr. Claudia – Dr. Claudia was Jean’s gynecologist prior to the Pure Movement’s government takeover. Jean knows that while Dr. Claudia doesn’t agree with the Pure Movement’s aims at all, she wears one of the movement’s pins because her husband is a genuine believer.

Papà – Jean’s father lives in southern Italy with Mamma and regularly FaceTimes with Jean and her family in the U.S.

Isabel Gerber – Prior to the Pure Movement’s takeover, Isabel was a professor at Georgetown and Lin’s fiancée. Isabel taught Spanish conversation.

Leo McClellan – Leo is Sam’s twin; they’re Jean and Patrick’s middle children. He’s 11.

Sam McClellan – Sam, Leo’s twin, is one of Jean and Patrick’s middle children. He’s 11.

Dr. Mendoza – Dr. Mendoza is the OB-GYN who takes over Dr. Claudia’s practice.

government a year ago, took away women’s jobs and autonomy, and fitted all women and girls with word **counters** that shock the wearer if the wearer speaks more than 100 words per day. For much of the novel, Jean struggles with her own guilt about having done nothing to stem the tide of religious fundamentalism despite having been friends in grad school with Jackie Juarez, a leading voice in the protests for women’s rights and representation. Jean now realizes that by not voting, protesting, and otherwise using her voice to protect her rights when she had the chance over the last 20 years, she (and other complacent women like her) really shouldn’t be surprised that the government has stripped away their rights.

However, throughout the novel, Jean’s ideas of what effective protests and resistance movements look like are challenged time and again. She spends much of the novel resenting her husband Patrick, who voices his opposition to government policies to Jean but refuses to stand up to anyone of consequence in his capacity as the president’s science advisor. However, Jean ultimately learns that Patrick’s seeming complacency is actually a protective front: he’s secretly part of a resistance network consisting of numerous men who appear to have bought into the system, but who work together (eventually with Jean) to ultimately poison the president and his advisors, thereby ending the Pure Movement’s control of the government. While the novel doesn’t go so far as to suggest that quiet rebellion from within is the only effective way to protest, it does propose that the form effective protests must take varies depending on the situation. Moreover, it also makes it clear that remaining passive in the face of injustice or oppression brings consequences that are both predictable and devastating.



LANGUAGE, COMMUNICATION, AND POWER

Vox makes the straightforward claim that language equals power. This, of course, is why the U.S.

government places word **counters** on all girls and women when the Pure Movement comes to power—depriving women of their voices is one of the easiest ways to control them. But in addition to depriving girls and women of agency, as when Steven shares with Jean that he’s been talking to Evan, his crush Julia’s father, about marrying Julia (rather than speaking to Julia herself), Vox also shows how without any way to communicate, social bonds disintegrate. For instance, Jean’s research focuses on people afflicted with Wernicke’s aphasia (a condition that causes people to speak in sentences that are complete nonsense, with no realization that nobody understands them), highlights the community-building aspect of language. People with Wernicke’s aphasia, the novel shows, can’t intelligibly communicate at all, even to express their basic needs.

Additionally, Jean describes at multiple points how the



THEMES

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ACTION, COMPLACENCY, AND RESISTANCE

Vox follows Dr. Jean McClellan, who was an esteemed cognitive linguist before the conservative Christian Pure Movement took over the U.S.

government has tried to stamp out even nonverbal communication between women, as when two young women were arrested for trying to communicate using rudimentary sign language in a grocery store. Jean even fears blowing kisses to her daughter Sonia where the government's surveillance cameras could see. And in the novel's climax, as Jean realizes the government plans to poison the world with a serum that will give everyone Wernicke's aphasia, she briefly describes what will happen—namely, that the global economy will collapse almost immediately. Depriving people of communication, Vox shows, dissolves social bonds and, on a smaller scale, allows those in power to subjugate anyone whose voice is silenced. But the worst-case scenario the novel explores suggests that on a global scale, without language with which to effectively communicate, society as we know it would cease to exist at all.



CHILDREN, INDOCTRINATION, AND ACCLIMATIZATION

Much of what motivates Jean to return to work for the oppressive U.S. government is the fact that doing so enables her to negotiate for her six-year-old daughter, Sonia, to have her word **counter** removed. In the year since girls and women had the counters put on, Jean watched her once bubbly and verbose daughter withdraw and clearly acclimatize the new system—it's a disturbing moment for Jean when Sonia comes home from school, proud that she won her class's competition of who can say the fewest words in a day. Through Sonia, Vox highlights how easy it is for the youngest children in a society to quickly adjust to a new normal that's actually not just or normal at all.

At the same time, Vox charts how Jean's 16-year-old son, Steven, slowly learns to buy into the Pure Movement's ideas. His indoctrination begins when his school introduces AP Religious Studies classes for all students—a class that he initially refuses to drop because it's going to make him more competitive on college applications. As the Pure Movement's takeover of American society continues, Steven is quickly drawn in by talk of the power and prestige it proposes he deserves as a young man. His indoctrination is so complete that he even reports his girlfriend, Julia, after they have consensual premarital sex—something for which only women are punished. Through Sonia and Steven's differing experiences of either being indoctrinated or acclimatizing to the Pure Movement's restrictive social structure and ideas, Vox highlights the malleability of children of all ages, and how this malleability makes them uniquely vulnerable to manipulation and indoctrination. However, Steven's choice to try to rescue Julia, and Sonia's relatively rapid return to speaking once her counter is removed, offers hope that this malleability works in both directions—children can acclimatize to truly horrific situations, but they can also unlearn harmful ideas and habits when given

the opportunity and guidance.



CONTROL, RELIGION, AND GENDER ESSENTIALISM

Vox illustrates how the fictional conservative Christian group, the Pure Movement, quickly takes over the United States by weaponizing Biblical teachings, particularly teachings about gender roles. Per Reverend Carl and the Pure Movement, the Bible lays out a hierarchy, with God and Jesus at the top, men next, and women below men. To ensure that men maintain power over their female relatives, women are fitted with word **counters**, which limit them to speaking 100 words per day. The Pure Movement justifies the counters by citing passages in the Bible and their own literature describing women as naturally obedient, quiet, and uniquely suited to serving men and managing the domestic sphere. It even attempts to make this sound like a desirable thing by referring to women as “queenly” rulers of their own homes. The novel illustrates how effective these attempts to appeal to women are when, prior to the takeover, Steven notes that even some of the girls in his class think the ideas of gender essentialism “make sense.” Still, this doesn't mean even genuinely religious women are happy about the takeover: even Olivia King, Jean's neighbor, attempts to take her own life when the regime she once supported arrests her daughter Julia for engaging in premarital sex. With this, Vox highlights religion's ability to offer people who seek power easy justification for implementing an extremely sexist and oppressive social order. That is, the novel suggests that there's a huge difference between being genuinely religious and even wanting to be a housewife, and weaponizing religion to exert total control over half the population.



CHOICE AND PERSONAL FULFILLMENT

As Jean's world seems to crumble around her, she finds herself struggling to balance her responsibilities as a wife and a parent with her personal desires—romantic, sexual, and professional alike. This tension, interestingly, is exactly what the Pure Movement sought to eliminate by confining women to the home to be wives and mothers: according to their philosophy, women are uniquely suited to the domestic sphere, and so if they have no other choice but to stay there, women will supposedly find happiness and fulfillment. However, Vox overwhelmingly suggests that in order to find personal fulfillment, a person needs the freedom to make their own choices about how to live their life. This lack of choice puts Jean in a difficult position. Prior to the Pure Movement's takeover, Jean was happy to balance a demanding job and parenthood. But as the government restricts Jean's agency, Jean struggles to figure out how to prioritize her children and her personal desires. And this leads to her making choices that she characterizes as

selfish, such as continuing to carry out an affair with a coworker, Lorenzo, with whom she conceives an unplanned baby.

Additionally, though Jean believes she's supposed to be equally protective of all her children, she finds herself focusing almost exclusively on Sonia and her unborn baby—who, if it's a girl, Jean believes she must go out of her way to save from being fitted with a **counter**. With this, the novel suggests that much of the angst Jean experiences as she struggles to navigate parenthood and relationships is actually caused by her lack of agency. For instance, though Jean has been conducting the affair with Lorenzo for some time, Patrick's unwillingness to stand up to the controlling government makes principled Lorenzo seem particularly attractive in comparison. Marriage and parenthood, the novel suggests, present their own challenges in any environment—but without the ability to make choices, what may have once been straightforward choices end up becoming impossibly difficult, and a person's many responsibilities become impossible to balance in a way that makes them feel happy and satisfied. The Pure Movement's calculated efforts to force women to dedicate themselves to childrearing and domestic labor thus backfire: in depriving women of the *choice* to commit themselves to tasks the Pure Movement deems innately feminine, the government takes away much of the happiness and fulfillment women like Jean may have otherwise gotten from such pursuits.

the ideology.

However, Jean realizes from the beginning that the counters can also be used to subvert expectations and protest her oppression. She does this first by choosing a blood-red counter for Sonia, rather than the pink one the technician suggested was “most appropriate” for a girl. And later, Jean discovers that Del has come up with a tool to remove the counters and replace them with fakes of his own creation, allowing women to blend in in public while speaking freely around those they trust. This helps support the novel's overarching claim that sometimes, the most effective forms of protest are those which aren't immediately obvious to outsiders, but rather allow someone to hide and protest in plain sight.



MANILA ENVELOPES

Manila envelopes symbolize the idea that effective protest or resistance movements often take unexpected forms—and, to uninformed outsiders, sometimes looks like compliance with the status quo. Jean discovers this as she begins to stealthily examine Patrick's top-secret files, which are housed in manila envelopes stamped with the presidential blue P, which to Jean indicates that the files are created by, and for, the government. Additionally, Jean takes Patrick's unwillingness to share any state secrets with her as proof that at least on some level, he supports the government's goals of silencing women and putting men in charge of their wives and female relatives. However, she later discovers that the resistance group Patrick is a part of is passing important government secrets along in these unassuming, seemingly government-sanctioned envelopes. Patrick, essentially, fooled Jean—and their shared enemies within the Pure Movement. Jean later takes this lesson and applies it to her work in the lab formulating first the anti-Wernicke's aphasia serum and then the serum that will induce aphasia. Taking Patrick's work into account, she realizes that the success of her mission depends on her ability to appear as though she's playing along and obeying the government's orders—while actually resisting them in secret.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



WORD COUNTERS

In *Vox*, the word counters that the government forces all American women and girls to wear symbolize oppression and control. The counters limit women and girls to 100 words per day and shock them if they go over their quota. On the surface, the counters are a straightforward symbol of oppression: there's no way to escape the counters, and no way to say more than 100 words per day without suffering. Women are thus disempowered and can no longer advocate for themselves or others. Jean also discovers that the government is piloting new counters, which decrease a woman's quota if they use foul language or language the government deems inappropriate. The new counters also require women to recite a daily series of religious affirmations, which do not count toward the 100-word quota. With these new counters, the government thus hopes to further manipulate women's minds: by requiring women to say several hundred words every day in support of the Pure Movement's ideals, the goal seems to be that women will ultimately buy into



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Berkley edition of *Vox* published in 2019.

Chapter 1 Quotes

☞☞ I shrug. By six, Sonia should have an army of ten thousand lexemes, individual troops that assemble and come to attention and obey the orders her small, still-plastic brain issues. Should have, if the three R's weren't now reduced to one: simple arithmetic. After all, one day my daughter will be expected to shop and to run a household, to be a devoted and dutiful wife. You need math for that, but not spelling. Not literature. Not a voice.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan (speaker), Patrick McClellan, Sonia McClellan

Related Themes:    

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 2

Explanation and Analysis

Over dinner, Patrick asks Jean how their six-year-old daughter, Sonia, is doing in terms of learning language. Jean, however, can only shrug, as she knows Sonia isn't learning anything about language, literature, or writing in school—and for that matter, Sonia, like all girls and women in the novel's fictional United States, wears a counter that shocks her if she speaks more than 100 words per day. Thus, Jean realizes that there's a huge gap between what Sonia should be able to do in terms of language, per standard child development standards, and what she actually can do. She should be able to mix and match about 10,000 lexemes (a linguistics term referring to a word, like walk, and its various forms, e.g., walked or walking) to express herself verbally and in writing. But because the Pure Movement has silenced women and no longer sees their ability to use language as essential, Sonia doesn't learn about words in school—instead, she just needs basic math, presumably so she can keep a basic budget in her future role as a housewife. This also articulates what the Pure Movement suggests is the only appropriate life path for women—one that Jean's intense angst throughout the novel clearly suggests brings few women happiness.

Chapter 3 Quotes

☞☞ “Test tomorrow in AP Religious Studies.”

When did sophomores start taking AP classes? And why isn't he doing something useful, like biology or history? I ask him about both.

“The religious studies course is new. They offered it to everyone, even the frosh babies. I think they're phasing it into the regular curriculum next year. Anyway,” he says from the kitchen, “that means no time for bio or history this year.”

“So what is it? Comparative theology? I guess I can tolerate that—even in a public school.”

[...] “Nah. More like, I don't know, philosophy of Christianity.”

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan, Steven McClellan (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 11

Explanation and Analysis

In this flashback, Jean's 16-year-old son Steven tells her about his AP Religious Studies class. Throughout the novel, Steven's trajectory helps the novel develop the idea that children are uniquely able to adapt to situations that, to an adult, would be totally unacceptable. This shows up here in Steven's uncritical acceptance of the course—and in Jean's incredulosity that it's being taught in a public school, to students she believes aren't even old enough to take advanced placement classes. Steven's lack of criticality means that he doesn't question the class, or what it's replacing: history and biology, two subjects that, notably, might help Steven to understand why the Pure Movement is actually extremely dangerous. And in turn, this leaves Steven vulnerable to essentially being brainwashed by the class and becoming a true believer of the Pure Movement. As a teen whose brain is still developing, he's uniquely vulnerable to being swayed by what he's learning in school—in a way that Jean, as an adult, is not. This is also why Jean remarks later that it only takes one generation for an entire culture to shift.

Chapter 4 Quotes

☞☞ All my words ricochet in my head as I listen, emerge from my throat in a heavy, meaningless sigh. And all I can think about are Jackie's last words to me.

Think about what you need to do to stay free.

Well, doing more than fuck all might have been a good place to start.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan, Jackie Juarez (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 16

Explanation and Analysis

Jean is listening to her husband and sons talk about her day, though due to her word counter, she isn't able to participate. Her forced silence makes her think about her college friend, Jackie Juarez, who encouraged Jean throughout their friendship to be politically active and stand up for her rights, to do "what you need to do to stay free." When Jean remarks that she should've done more than "fuck all," or nothing, she shoulders some of the blame for the Pure Movement's takeover. Throughout the novel, Jean observes that because she and many other women like her didn't take the threat the Pure Movement posed seriously, they didn't protest and use their voices or votes when they had the chance. Now, they're living in a world where they're forced to be silent, and where they aren't at all free—and Jean suggests in retrospect that this should have been the predictable consequence of her (and other people's) years of passivity and inaction.

Sonia has woken up in the night with a nightmare, and she yells for Jean to save her from the monster. Jean races to help her daughter—but rather than comforting Sonia, Jean's primary goal is to stop Sonia from speaking. This is because, at this point, Sonia doesn't know that her word counter will administer an electric shock if she speaks over 100 words in a day. Jean, in other words, doesn't want to traumatize her daughter further by having her receive a shock in response to her fear. This also highlights the counters' cruelty: they don't differentiate between carefully chosen words and a child's screams for help in a moment of fear. However, the way Jean has to do stop Sonia from speaking is inherently violent, even if her intentions are good. She has to physically restrain and silence Sonia, something that is in no way comforting or gentle. In this sense, the counters prevent Jean from parenting her children the way she would like to, with kindness and compassion.

Jean's inability to parent the way she would want to in an ideal world extends to her sons, as well. Their ability to speak and express themselves without punishment means that Jean prioritizes Sonia over them in this situation, despite their obvious distress at their sister's screams and their mother's hurry to reach Sonia. This impresses on Jean yet again that despite the Pure Movement's insistence that relegating women to the home and taking away their words will make them perfect wives and mothers, the opposite is actually true. Jean is forced into a situation where she must make awful choices about which child to prioritize, and ignoring her sons makes her feel like a "lousy mother."

Chapter 7 Quotes

💬 Mommy, please don't let it get me don't let it get me don't—

Sam and Leo start crying. For the smallest of moments, I register a single thought: lousy mother. My boys are in distress, and I'm moving past them, uncaring and oblivious. I'll worry about this damage later, if I'm in the condition to worry about anything.

Two steps into Sonia's small room, I vault onto her bed, one hand searching for her mouth, clamping onto it. My free hand gropes under her sheets for the hard metal of the wrist counter.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan, Sonia McClellan (speaker), Leo McClellan, Sam McClellan

Related Themes:    

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 26

Explanation and Analysis

Chapter 8 Quotes

💬 "You think I should garden and cook more? You think the work I do is less important than—I don't know—crafts?"

"Not you, Mom. Other women. The ones who just wanna get out of the house and have some kind of identity." He picked up the book and kissed me goodnight. "Anyway, it's just a stupid class."

"I wish you'd drop it," I said.

"No way, José. I need the AP credits for college."

"Why? So you can major in modern Christian thought?"

"No. So I can get into college."

And that was how they did it. Sneaking in a course here, a club there. Anything to lure kids with promises of increasing their competitiveness.

Such a simple thing, really.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan, Steven McClellan

(speaker)

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 35

Explanation and Analysis

In a flashback to before the Pure Movement took over the government entirely, Steven explains to Jean how some of the things he's learning in his AP Religious Studies class about gender essentialism makes sense—and why he isn't going to drop the class. First, the beginning of this quotation highlights how the Pure Movement's religious ideology teaches young men like Steven to devalue women's desires and experiences. Steven is learning that a woman who just "[wants to] get out of the house and have some kind of identity" is misguided—per the Pure Movement, all women, but especially the kind of woman he describes here, will be happier once they're forced to stay home as wives and mothers. At this point, he's still willing to differentiate between those women who tie their identities to (unspecified) jobs that Steven seems to deem frivolous and his mother's important work as a scientist, but he later comes to devalue *all* women who want to work, including his mother.

Then, Steven refuses to drop the class because he knows it's going to make him a more competitive applicant when he applies to college. That is, the class itself matters much less to him than what it will do for him. But this, as his trajectory throughout the novel shows, makes him (and other kids and teens) uniquely vulnerable to manipulation and brainwashing. Steven willingly attends the class, absorbs its ideas, and ultimately comes to believe that what he's learning is right—turning him into a willing member of the Pure Movement.

Chapter 9 Quotes

💬 "I had no idea," she said.

"No idea about what?"

"These numbers." She pointed to one of the charts, now being televised with a prepared voice-over of Baby Blue's voice. She had moved on from rape and was reciting statistics on antidepressant usage. "Jeez. One in six? That's awful."

No one in the studio audience was paying attention to Jackie's claims of skewed statistics, of the correlation-causation fallacy, of the fact that of course no one was taking selective serotonin reuptake inhibitors in 1960, because they didn't exist.

That was how it started. Three women with a stack of pie charts and people like Olivia.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan, Olivia King (speaker), Jackie Juarez

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 40

Explanation and Analysis

In a flashback to before the Pure Movement took over, Olivia has come over to Jean's house and invited herself to watch a talk show featuring Jackie Juarez and two women dressed in pastel-colored clothing (one of them is referred to as Baby Blue in this passage). This passage helps to explain how even women came to buy into the Pure Movement's ideology, though Jean is careful to explain to readers that they were, essentially, tricked. Here, the women on TV share carefully constructed charts and graphs, seemingly suggesting that things were better in the 1960s (and implying that because of this, society should revert to what it was in the 1960s).

As Jean notes, however, when it comes to something like antidepressant usage, comparing the 1960s to the present day is like comparing apples to oranges, as the first antidepressant wasn't introduced until 1987. This doesn't mean people weren't depressed in the 1960s, it just means that people weren't taking SSRIs for them (and in fact, there's a prevalent stereotype that midcentury housewives were dealing with their mental health issues by drinking heavily and taking benzodiazepines like Valium, a dangerous combination).

But though Jackie (to viewers of this talk show) and Jean (to readers) try to explain how these charts are misleading, Jean notes that plenty of people like Olivia aren't willing to think critically about what they're hearing, or they perhaps don't know how. They hear about a supposedly alarming uptick in SSRI usage in the last 30 years and think the Pure Movement's remedy—to return to a simpler time, when women were supposedly happier and not depressed—makes sense. As a result of such selective information, then, these women give their support to the movement and become complicit in American women's subjugation.

Chapter 13 Quotes

💬 "Our hope"—Reverend Carl is in full preacher mode now—"is that people will settle down, find their feet in the new rhythm, and we won't need these silly little bracelets any longer." He makes a disdainful gesture with his hand, as if he's talking about a trivial fashion accessory and not a torture device.

Related Characters: Reverend Carl Corbin (speaker), Dr. Jean McClellan

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 58

Explanation and Analysis

Reverend Carl has come to ask Jean to return to work on her anti-aphasia serum, and they're now discussing women's word counters. He's implied that soon, the counters will come off, and here explains how and why this shift will occur. Essentially, he suggests that as women become accustomed to not speaking, they won't need the negative reinforcement the counters provide in order to stay silent. Astute readers may pick up on the fact that adults like Jean are in no way used to the counters yet after a year and seem to show no signs of becoming truly accustomed to them—and so, it seems far more likely that Reverend Carl doesn't plan to remove counters until a new generation of women have come of age, having been trained from childhood not to speak.

Additionally, this passage highlights the power of language to shape a person's preferred reality. Jean has been shocked by her counter before; she knows it's a "torture device" and sees it as something awful. In contrast, Reverend Carl refers to the counter as a "bracelet," suggesting it's a "trivial fashion accessory." Through his word choice, he seeks to minimize the idea that the counters are bad, controlling and abusive.

Chapter 20 Quotes

☛ Instead of standing next to Patrick, or even at the far end of the family line, bookending our kids, I'm fifth. After my husband, after Steven, after the eleven-year-old twins. And Sonia has made me smaller than everyone except for her. I manage a forced smile and take her into my arms, pressing her head against me so she can't see the tears that are welling up, that I won't be able to contain.

[...]

And so here we are. Me, my daughter, and the wrist counters that keep us in line. I wonder what Jackie would have to say about it. Probably something like *Good work, Jean. You gassed up the car and drove it straight into hell. Enjoy the burn.*

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan (speaker), Patrick McClellan, Sonia McClellan, Steven McClellan, Jackie

Juarez, President Myers, Leo McClellan, Sam McClellan

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 92-93

Explanation and Analysis

Sonia has brought Jean a drawing of their family—and it's this drawing, and seeing the damage the Pure Movement has done to her family, that encourages Jean to negotiate with President Myers and return to her work on a treatment for Wernicke's aphasia.

Sonia's drawing symbolically suggests that the Pure Movement has minimized women and made them smaller and less powerful. Rather than portraying her mother like an adult and an authority figure, Sonia has portrayed Jean as visually smaller—and as such, less important and less powerful—than even her 11-year-old sons. That is, in this version of the United States, young boys are more valuable and have more power and agency than adult women. That this notion is coming from Sonia, who's only six years old, impresses upon Jean how fully the Pure Movement's ideology has seeped into the mainstream and how it's made all its warped perspectives on gender essentialism seem normal to a young girl.

As disturbed by the drawing as she is, Jean also finds that she's not surprised that this has happened. This is because she recognizes that, by not standing up for her rights when she had the chance to, she is complicit in the Pure Movement's takeover of American society. Jean thinks of Jackie often as she considers her own previous complacency, and she uses Jackie as a model for how she should have responded—and how she should choose to act going forward if she means to change anything for herself and her daughter.

Chapter 21 Quotes

☛ [...] I'm thinking I did a crackerjack job on the behavioral part, conditioning Sonia with bribes of cookies and marshmallows to keep her words unspoken. Someone should take away my mothering license.

I keep reminding myself it isn't my fault. I didn't vote for Myers. I didn't vote at all, actually.

And here's Jackie's voice again, telling me what an acquiescent shit I am.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan (speaker), Sonia McClellan, Jackie Juarez, President Myers

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 96

Explanation and Analysis

Jean has agreed to return to her work on a cure for Wernicke's aphasia in exchange for having Sonia's counter removed, and she's beating herself up for helping to train Sonia to be quiet over the last year. Importantly, in teaching Sonia to be quiet by bribing her with sweets, Jean did what she thought she had to do to keep her daughter safe. In an ideal world, of course, Sonia would be free to speak. And Jean, as a cognitive linguist, would do everything she could to facilitate Sonia learning language. But under the Pure Movement, Jean didn't have that choice. Her choices were to teach her daughter to stay quiet in order to remain safe and unharmed—or allow Sonia to learn the consequences of speaking on her own, something that Jean has characterized as a different mark of a bad mother. As Jean's choices for how to parent her daughter were taken from her, she had to do the best with the options she did have—and as she notes here, there was no way for her to be a good mother in that context. Sonia may be physically unharmed, but Jean has still done harm by teaching her that it's a good thing to be silent. As the Pure Movement took away Jean's choices, they ironically took away her ability to be what she believes is a good mother—the very thing it wants her to be.

And once again, Jean comes back to the idea that she's in this pickle because she didn't do anything years ago to stand up for women's rights. As she (and Jackie) sees it, Jean stood by and allowed the Pure Movement to take over American society, and then the White House and other government branches, when she didn't either vote or participate in protests in support of women's rights.

Chapter 22 Quotes

“I haven't talked about [marriage] with Julia,” he drawls. I've talked about it with Evan.”

My blood is beginning to boil. “Does Julia get a say?”

There's no response from my son, only a bewildered look, as if I've suddenly begun speaking in tongues. We stare at each other across the table like strangers until Patrick interrupts.

“Let it go, Jean. No sense in fighting about it. He's too young, anyway.” Then he looks over at Steven. “Way too young.”

“Wrong again, Dad. A guy from the Department of Health and Welfare came to our school today. Major assembly. He talked about how next year they're rolling out a new program. Get this: ten thousand bucks, full college tuition, and a guaranteed government job for anyone who's married by eighteen. Boys, of course. And another ten thousand for each kid you have. Pretty sweet, huh?”

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan, Patrick McClellan, Steven McClellan (speaker), Evan King, Julia King

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 101

Explanation and Analysis

Steven shares over dinner that he's been speaking with their neighbor Evan about marrying Evan's daughter, Julia—without Julia's consent. Jean finds this abhorrent, but Steven's glib demeanor here highlights how effective the Pure Movement has been at teaching him to devalue women's desires and thoughts. It seems not to occur to him that he should consult Julia in the matter of her own marriage, suggesting that he doesn't see her as a fully formed human being anymore. Rather, because she's female, he sees her as something that he can essentially own—if he speaks to her father about it first.

Then, Steven's explanation of the government program to encourage young marriages highlights how the Pure Movement has drawn in young men specifically. It makes it clear that their policies and ideals are good for them—it will give them a steady income, bonuses, and an education. On the surface, these are all good things, and it's understandable why Steven would want them. But Steven is only so drawn in by these rewards because he's been successfully taught to see women as a means to an end, not as fellow people.

Chapter 31 Quotes

☝☝ What would Jackie do? Speed after him? Probably. Spit back? Likely. What's on my mind, though, is what Patrick would do: absolutely nothing.

He'd sigh and shake his head at the barbarism, and then he'd clean up the mess of phlegm and forget about Mr. Midlife Crisis. And Lorenzo? Lorenzo would beat the living shit out of the bastard.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan (speaker), Patrick McClellan, Jackie Juarez, Lorenzo Rossi

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 135

Explanation and Analysis

On Jean's drive home from work, a man spit into her open car window. Now, Jean considers what some of the important people in her life would do in response. Jackie, Jean's politically active friend from college, would, she believes, fight back in some way. Throughout the novel, Jean takes Jackie as an example of what she should do, or what she should have done. So, by considering what Jackie would do, Jean expresses that she'd like to be more like Jackie, who would be more willing to go after this guy.

Then, Jean compares Patrick and Lorenzo's hypothetical reactions to the incident. Throughout the novel, Jean describes Patrick as "weak" and takes issue with what she sees as his complicity in the current political system. Thus, she finds it almost offensive that Patrick would do nothing if a man spit on him, or on Jean. Lorenzo, on the other hand, would fight back—and especially given the current circumstances and Patrick's seeming complicity, Jean finds this wildly attractive. At this point in the novel, she still prioritizes decisive, obvious action, like Lorenzo hypothetically beating this guy up or Jackie spitting back, over what is later revealed to be Patrick's quiet and subtle resistance to the status quo.

Chapter 32 Quotes

☝☝ Only after I've shut down FaceTime do I notice the manila envelope with its TOP SECRET stenciling on Patrick's desk. Whoever came up with the idea of labeling classified documents with larger-than-life red stenciling that advertises—or at least hints at—the contents was a shmuck, I think. You might as well put a tag that says OPEN ME! on it. If it were up to me, I'd hide all secrets in back copies of *Reader's Digest*.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan (speaker), Patrick McClellan

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 140

Explanation and Analysis

After FaceTiming her parents in Patrick's office, Jean notices a top-secret envelope on Patrick's desk and opens it. Here, though, she scoffs at how obvious the envelope is, and how bad of a job she believes it does of keeping government secrets private. However, Jean has these thoughts because she's actually misinterpreting what this envelope even is. Rather than being a government classified document, this is a document intended for the resistance. In that sense, making it look like a government document is, in fact, akin to hiding it in "back copies of *Reader's Digest*," in that it's masquerading as something it isn't. This sets up Jean's starting point as she learns over the course of the novel that Patrick is, in fact, a key member of the resistance. He maintains that position because he looks like he fits in and agrees with the status quo—when in actuality, he's simply weaponizing his seeming belonging to be able to pass important information along to people who can then help take down the government.

Chapter 38 Quotes

☝☝ "Take a good look at me, Jean. I'm a black woman."
"I noticed. So?"

"So how long do you think it's gonna be before Reverend Carl and his holy Pure Blue sheep get it in their heads that it ain't just women and men who were made differently under God's eyes, but blacks and whites? You think mixed marriages like mine are part of the plan? If you do, you're not as smart as I thought."

I feel myself going red. "I never thought about it."

"Course you never. Look, I don't mean to be unkind, but you white gals, all you're worried about is, well, all you're worried about is you white gals."

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan, Sharon Ray (speaker), Reverend Carl Corbin, Del Ray/The Mailman

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 163-164

Explanation and Analysis

At the Rays' farm, Jean discovers that Del and Sharon are key members of the resistance. Here, Sharon explains to Jean exactly why she and her husband are involved: they're in an interracial marriage, and they both believe that it won't be long before the Pure Movement decides to institute racial segregation in addition to subjugating women. This passage is important primarily because Sharon, like Jackie in years past, calls Jean out for living in a "bubble" and thinking only of herself and women like her, or as Sharon notes, "white gals." Sharon adds nuance to Jackie's earlier accusations that Jean didn't think she had to vote or protest anything, a belief it's implied Jean held because she's white, relatively affluent, straight, and has (or had) a good job. That is, all of Jean's identity markers were working to her advantage prior to the government takeover—and Sharon suggests that it's relatively common for people with Jean, who have this privilege, to disregard those with less privilege. This offers another reason why Jean and other privileged women like her didn't protest when they had the chance: they didn't think they needed to, as they didn't suffer the same kinds of discrimination or struggles as a woman who was Black like Sharon, or gay like Jackie, did.

☛ I drive the long way back home, stopping at a 7-Eleven to pick up a pack of Camels. I could smoke it out of me, I think, poison the little palace, practice Teratology 101 in the privacy of my own home. Abortion the old-fashioned way.

An abortion is not an option.

It isn't just Reverend Carl and his pack of Pure fanatics. They have to put limits on choice for other reasons, for pragmatic reasons. The way things are, the way women are, no one would want a girl. No sane parent would want to choose a wrist-counter color for a three-month-old. I wouldn't.

In three days, I'll know if I have to.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan (speaker), Lorenzo Rossi, Dr. Mendoza

Related Themes:    

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 167-168

Explanation and Analysis

A doctor has just confirmed Jean's pregnancy. Now, Jean

considers how she might attempt an abortion (or, at least, induce enough congenital defects to end her pregnancy or render the fetus unable to survive after birth). Jean doesn't want to be pregnant in part because the father is Lorenzo, her lover with whom she's conducting an illegal affair.

However, the bigger reason to not want to be pregnant is the fear that she'll have a girl—and that she'll then have to subject that daughter to a word counter beginning at only a few months old. As someone versed in linguistics, cognition, neuroscience, and basic child development, Jean knows this is its own kind of abuse.

Moreover, Jean suggests she isn't alone in not wanting to be pregnant right now, and specifically, in not wanting to have a girl. She implies that many women see their subjugation as extreme and wouldn't wish it on their daughters. But for the Pure Movement to continue, it needs women to continue having babies of both sexes, and thus it has more reasons to forbid abortion beyond those rooted in religion.

Chapter 41 Quotes

☛ “See, he says, “this is why the old way didn't work. There's always something. Always some sick kid or a school play or menstrual camps or maternity leave. Always a problem.”

I open my mouth, but not to speak. It just falls open in disbelief.

Morgan hasn't finished. He picks up a pen and jabs the air with it. “You need to get it in your head, Jean. You women aren't dependable. The system doesn't work the way it was. Take the fifties. Everything was fine. Everyone had a nice house and a car in the garage and food on the table. And things still ran smoothly! We didn't need women in the workforce. You'll see, once you get over all this anger. You'll see it's going to be better. Better for your kids.”

Related Characters: Morgan LeBron (speaker), Dr. Jean McClellan

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 174

Explanation and Analysis

Morgan has called Jean to his office to scold her for being late. Rather than just reprimanding her, though, Morgan goes on an impassioned tirade about why women are unfit for working outside the home. His tirade helps explain why he's bought into the Pure Movement's elevation of men: it confirms what the novel overwhelmingly suggests are Morgan's already sexist attitudes toward women. That is, the Pure Movement is simply a convenient way for Morgan

to justify his sexism and find a way to use it to his advantage (or what he believes is to his advantage), as by not having to work with women at all.

It's also worth digging into how flawed Morgan's logic is on various levels. First, Morgan assumes that only women and mothers deal with children—the implication here is that a father would never stay home with a sick child or need or want to take time off of work to see their child perform in a play. This is, of course, not true. Then, he suggests that in the 1950s, "Everything was fine," claiming that people were financially secure when women overwhelmingly stayed home while men worked. However, this ignores that working-class and single women have always had to work, and that generally speaking, not everyone was as affluent in the 1950s as Morgan seems to think. He's cherry picking from stereotypes to justify a cultural return to the 1950s.

Chapter 45 Quotes

💬 "Did you do it?"

"I *had* to, Mom. If I didn't, they'd all think—" He stops short, and a smile creeps up one side of his mouth. "Evil triumphs when good men do nothing. That's what they say, right?"

He's got the essence of Burke's quote, if not the exact words. But I know what he means, and I nod.

Jackie would like that.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan, Steven McClellan (speaker), Patrick McClellan, Julia King

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 192

Explanation and Analysis

At school, Steven's teacher made the class watch Julia King's televised shaming, had them shout slurs at her, and then had students write letters to her using slurs and telling her she deserves her punishment. Here, Steven explains to Jean why he participated—and in a satisfying turn of events, he implies that he's no longer a Pure Movement believer. Steven didn't say horrible things about and to Julia because he believes they're true—he loves her. Rather, he said them to blend in with his classmates. And blending in, he hopes, will allow him to work from within the system to bring it down. This highlights young people's capacity to learn and change: Steven did genuinely believe in the Pure Movement for a while, but now, his loyalties have shifted.

Steven is (likely unwittingly) following in his father's footsteps: Patrick, too, looks like he's going along with the status quo, when he's actually a very important member of the resistance movement. This passage thus furthers readers' understanding of the manila envelopes' symbolism. They look like they should contain top-secret government information, when they are actually intended for the resistance. The envelopes, like Steven and Patrick themselves, look as though they fit in with the status quo, when they really work to upend it. As Jean simply accepts Steven's explanation without comment, noting to readers that Jackie would be proud of him, it suggests that Jean has come a long way in understanding that effective protest doesn't have to be uniformly loud and obvious. It can also be quiet and hide in plain sight.

Chapter 48 Quotes

💬 *Gone to look for Julia. Love you. S.*

Related Characters: Steven McClellan (speaker), Dr. Jean McClellan, Patrick McClellan, Julia King

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 205

Explanation and Analysis

Patrick shows Jean a note from Steven, informing his parents that he's run away to look for Julia. This note—and Steven's actions—highlight clearly that children like Steven have immense capacity to adapt to new circumstances. This is why, for most of the last year, Steven has been a genuine believer in the Pure Movement: he was vulnerable to their manipulation and promises that he'd be powerful in the new system. But now that he's seen his crush Julia taken away for having consensual premarital sex with him, Steven has undergone a change. Seeing Julia taken away for something they both wanted to do—and for something that Steven actually reported her for—makes him realize the consequences of going along with such a system. Now, Steven realizes it's his responsibility to make things right. He's not only able to reject everything about the Pure Movement that he learned over the last year, he's also willing and able to take it to heart that it's up to him to take action and help fix things if he wants to see them change.

Chapter 50 Quotes

“Someone should shut that woman up,” Olivia says. “Permanently.”

Oh, Olivia, I think, what the hell did you expect?

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan, Olivia King (speaker), Jackie Juarez, Julia King

Related Themes:    

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 214

Explanation and Analysis

When Jean realizes that the government plans to reverse-engineer her cure for Wernicke's aphasia and administer it to women to permanently rob them of their voices, Jean thinks back to two years ago when her neighbor Olivia said this in response to seeing Jackie Juarez on TV. Jean realizes that Olivia was likely speaking hyperbolically here: that is, Olivia certainly wanted outspoken and politically-minded Jackie to “shut up” and stop talking about women's rights on TV, but she almost certainly saw no reason to actually force Jackie to be permanently silent. Jean, too, never expected the U.S. to reach the point where they put counters on women to cap the words they can speak per day at 100. But in this fictional near future, the government has done just that—and it seeks to “shut wom[e]n up, [...] Permanently.” When Jean asks Olivia what she expected, she suggests that they were all wrong to not take things more seriously early on, and to begin to normalize women's silence by speaking this way, even if one is just exaggerating for effect.

Olivia's character on the whole helps the novel explore the idea that there are indeed women who find the Pure Movement's basic ideas attractive. They're devout Christians and believe women belong at home, caring for their children. And while the novel suggests that it's fine for women to want these things for themselves, it nevertheless shows through Jean and even through Olivia that the problem comes when women are denied the ability to make choices about their own lives. For instance, even Olivia comes to push back on the Pure Movement when it takes her own daughter away.

“When I first started experiments with lab animals, I had one golden rule: don't name them. In other words, don't think of them as pets; don't think of them as anything other than a way to get from point A to point B. Think of them as test tubes or Petri dishes or microscope slides, nothing more than innate vehicles to fill and observe. While I hold each tiny mouse for Lorenzo to inject with a potion that will either cure it or kill it, all I can think of is the names I've given them:

Jackie. Lin. Jean.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan (speaker), Jackie Juarez, Lorenzo Rossi, Dr. Lin Kwan

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 215

Explanation and Analysis

Jean and Lorenzo are testing a neuroprotein on mice; one will kill them, and the other is what will cure Wernicke's aphasia. They've recently discovered that the government plans to reverse-engineer the cure and use it to take away women's voices, thereby rendering the counters useless. Knowing this, Jean breaks her longstanding rule to not name lab animals and names the mice after herself and her female friends. This represents Jean's understanding of the impact of her research. She's no longer a noble scientist in search of a cure for a life-altering condition: she's complicit in subjugating not just nameless and faceless American women, but also her friends, family, and even herself. Jean also recognizes that for the cruel men in government, she, Jackie, Lin, and other women are exactly what Jean has considered the mice for all these years: “innate vehicles to fill and observe.” That is, they don't see women as fully human—they see them as vessels to control and benefit from.

Chapter 53 Quotes

“I click open the Honda, climb in, and think about what I would pray for—a boy or a girl. Stay or leave. Watch Sonia taken away from me, or, in a marginally more pleasant scenario, watch while some uniformed male nurse, following orders, injects her with a concoction that will take all her words away, forever. I don't think I could stand it either way.

I pray to a god I don't believe in for a girl, so I don't have to witness any of this. And I pray to that same god for a boy, so I never have to leave my Sonia.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan (speaker), Sonia McClellan, Lorenzo Rossi

Related Themes:



Page Number: 224-225

Explanation and Analysis

Lorenzo has shared with Jean that he'd like to try to get her out of the U.S. by having her use his deceased wife's Italian passport. Jean has agreed to go, if she finds out that the baby she's pregnant with is female. On the drive back to the lab, Jean considers the options and possibilities in front of her, none of which seem like good options to her. This reinforces the idea that because the Pure Movement has taken away so many choices from women, women are in an impossible situation and don't have every option available to them to be able to care for their families. There is no choice that will allow Jean to be okay with having either a girl or a boy, and there's no choice that will save Sonia from having her voice permanently taken away. Ironically, then, the Pure Movement has hobbled women's ability to be the good wives and mothers it wants them to be. Jean found purpose and fulfillment in being a parent before the Movement's takeover, when she was able to make choices (including to work). But without any options available to her that she actually wants, Jean is distraught.

communicate will destroy civilization and society as they know it. With this, the novel proposes that communication is one of the most important qualities that allows human civilization to flourish and come up with things like supply chains, banks, factories, and even mass transit. Without language, people won't be able to talk about their money in the banks, or follow instructions in a factory, or read directions or signs on the road—or know what train or bus to get on. This will reduce people to living a subsistence lifestyle, simply trying to survive off the land. Understanding what will happen helps spur Jean to resist and find ways to best the men who wish to use her serum for evil—to save herself, but also to save the rest of humanity from devastation.

Chapter 65 Quotes

☞ “What the hell did you do that for?” he says.

I open my eyes and see the soldier, gun hand still trembling after what might have been his first kill, looking from me to Lorenzo to Morgan to the dead number 412 in the cage above me. Before he can answer, Morgan opens his mouth again.

“That’s just terrific. Just great. You idiot. I should put you in one of these cages, except you don’t have enough of a brain for me to work with. Do you know how much these animals cost?”

“Apparently more than I do, Morgan,” I say.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan, Morgan LeBron (speaker)

Related Themes:

Page Number: 270

Explanation and Analysis

When Jean falls into a chimp's cage and it begins to attack her, an accompanying soldier shoots the chimp to save Jean. Morgan scolds the soldier, however, citing the chimp's expense. This exchange does two things. First, it highlights Morgan's utter depravity and his cruelty. He doesn't see Jean as valuable or important, and through his reaction, he shows that he'd rather see her die than lose a valuable lab animal. However, on the flip side, the soldier's choice to shoot the chimp hopefully suggests that there are people, even those who seem to be fully on board with the government's aims, who can acknowledge that women are people too, and that they deserve safety and respect. That is, the soldier makes it clear that there's still time for the United States to recover from the Pure Movement's takeover and restore rights to women, in part because this

Chapter 61 Quotes

☞ Reverend Carl Corbin must be insane, truly insane. Has he thought ahead to the inevitable outcome? Does he realize the havoc, not only in Europe, but everywhere, his plot will wreak? Supply chains—gone. Banks and stock markets—gone. Mass transit, any transit, really, other than foot traffic and the occasional horse—gone. Factories—gone. Within weeks, most of the world's population will die of hunger or dehydration or violence. The ones who are left will be eking life out in a twisted *Little House on the Prairie* existence, building from the ground up, one haystack and corn silo at a time.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan (speaker), Lorenzo Rossi, Morgan LeBron, Reverend Carl Corbin

Related Themes:

Page Number: 257

Explanation and Analysis

Before the first human trial of Jean's anti-aphasia serum, she considers what will happen if—and she believes when—Reverend Carl reverse-engineers it and uses it to poison all of Europe. The way Jean sees it, inducing aphasia in everyone and depriving them of their ability to

shows that there are still men who recognize women's humanity and inherent value.

Chapter 67 Quotes

☛ A million years ago—it was only twenty, but it feels like a million, it feels like tens of millions, like all the lifetimes of the entire world—Jackie asked me what I would do to stay free. Last night, over a kitchen counter that seems as distant as that Georgetown apartment, I asked Patrick if he would do anything, if he would kill.

Right now, with a half-baked formula on the table and Reverend Carl scolding Steven on the television, I put all the questions together and come up with a single answer.

Yes, I would do anything. I would kill.

The woman who thinks these words doesn't sound like me at all.

Or maybe she does.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan (speaker), Patrick McClellan, Steven McClellan, Jackie Juarez, Dr. Lin Kwan, Morgan LeBron, Reverend Carl Corbin, Isabel Gerber

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 282

Explanation and Analysis

After discovering that Morgan is holding Jackie, Lin, and Isabel hostage, and then seeing Reverend Corbin shame Steven on TV, Jean comes to the conclusion that she would absolutely kill if it meant saving her loved ones. This represents a huge shift for Jean's character, as up until this point, she's constantly berated herself for passively going along with things. And while she acknowledges that her complacency has led to people getting hurt—and to women's subjugation under the Pure Movement's control—Jean has been less than willing to actually do anything about it. But now, as she sees her friends and her own child threatened, she's spurred to action. It's this drive to do something and protect her loved ones that, mere hours after this, leads Jean to shoot and kill Morgan—a huge choice that ultimately enables Patrick to bring down the government by killing top-ranking government officials and allows Jean and her children to escape the country.

Chapter 77 Quotes

☛ Patrick is number thirteen. The Judas Iscariot of the Oval Office. As I lie here in bed, numbed by the spin of the ceiling fan, these religious coincidences strike me as funny. Water, wine, thirteen men. Reverend Carl and his insanity.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan (speaker), Patrick McClellan, Reverend Carl Corbin, President Myers, Bobby Myers

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 317

Explanation and Analysis

Jean is waiting at the Rays' farm while Patrick attends a meeting for Project Wernicke, during which he plans to poison the president and his top advisors, including Reverend Carl. The fact that Jean finds the similarities between this breakfast meeting and the Last Supper funny and satisfying points to the idea that religion itself, or the ideas a given religion espouses, aren't inherently bad. What's bad is what people choose to do with religion, or how they interpret or manipulate religious ideas. In this situation, Jean likens Patrick to Judas, who sold Jesus out to the Romans, leading to Jesus's crucifixion. In the Bible, Judas is the villain of that story—while here, Patrick is the Judas figure, and he's actually the hero. But this, of course, is up to interpretation: a true believer of the Pure Movement is going to see Patrick as the villain here. And similarly, while the novel acknowledges that there's nothing wrong with being Christian in general, or with a woman interpreting Christian teachings as supporting her choice to be a housewife and mother, what is wrong is forcing everyone to adhere to a specific interpretation of religion and using that interpretation to structure every facet of public and private life.

Chapter 80 Quotes

☛ *Imagine, Jeanie, she wrote. Twenty-five percent in the Senate and the House. Twenty-five! You should come back and get in on it. Maybe next year, I wrote back. And I meant it.*

For now, though, Jackie has my financial and moral support. I'm not ready to get into politics, not just yet.

Related Characters: Dr. Jean McClellan, Jackie Juarez (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 326

Explanation and Analysis

Several months after the main events of the novel, Jean and her children are safe in Italy, while Jackie is in the United States helping to get women elected to the House and Senate. They regularly exchange letters, and in the one Jean quotes here, Jackie encourages Jean to come home and run for office herself. It's a sign of how much Jean has changed that while she defers for now, she does genuinely intend to return and enter politics. This speaks to her newfound belief in the importance of doing whatever she can to protect women's rights. For now, this means supporting

Jackie and her causes with money and "moral support." Eventually, it will mean carving out a place for herself in Congress, where Jean will be able to help make policies to protect women—and protect those already in place.

Finally, this passage also speaks to the peace that Jean finds once her ability to choose her life path is restored to her. Jean isn't ready to leap into politics right now—but that doesn't mean she won't be happy to get involved in the future. That is, part of the peace and fulfillment Jean exudes in this closing chapter comes from the fact that she's once again in control of her choices now that she's no longer under the Pure Movement's control.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1

Jean wouldn't believe anyone who told her that in a week's time, she'd unseat the president, the Pure Movement, and Morgan LeBron. But she wouldn't argue, as she, her six-year-old daughter Sonia, and all women wear word **counters** on their wrists. Jean's husband, Patrick, and their sons, Steven, Leo, and Sam do not. Over dinner, Patrick asks Sonia yes or no questions about what she learned in school today. Sam and Leo ask her open-ended questions about school, which she can't answer. With only five words left for the day, Jean can't tell her sons herself that girls only listen to their teachers now, all of whom are male.

Patrick asks Jean, a cognitive linguist, if Sonia is learning, but Jean just shrugs. By age six Sonia should be very verbal, but girls no longer learn reading and writing in school. They learn some math and mostly home economics, but girls don't need voices to learn how to run a household and be "dutiful wi[ves]" one day. Annoyed, Jean snaps that she's not a cognitive linguist anymore and scoops Sonia up to put her to bed. Jean's last word of the day is "goodnight" to Sonia. She hums a bedtime song while Patrick watches from the doorway, looking dejected.

After initially offering readers hope that everything will turn out okay by the novel's end, Vox plunges readers right into Jean's nightmare. In the novel's present, Jean isn't able to effectively parent her children because of her counter, which severely limits her ability to speak. While Jean seems angry and frustrated about this restriction, six-year-old Sonia seems resigned—an early suggestion that children are, in this case unfortunately, very able to adapt to new situations.



Readers still don't have the full picture of what life is like in this alternate U.S., or why, but Jean shares here that women are now relegated to being housewives. This is especially grating for Jean, who seems to have once been an esteemed scientist before she was forced to care for her children full time. She's not happy that someone else made this choice for her, pointing to how important the ability to make choices about one's own life is to one's happiness.



CHAPTER 2

Jean crawls into bed and pretends she's reading Shakespeare or Dante's *Inferno*. She remembers watching international new reports on the United States. That was before the government took control of all TV and made women wear **counters**. Every country's news mocked the U.S. Watching an Italian skit about the U.S., Jean, who's Italian, wondered what the Italians really think about Americans right now. She hasn't been back to Italy since before Sonia was born, and she can't go back now. A few months before the counters, Jean tried to renew her family's passports and get one for Sonia. At a passport application center, the clerk invalidated Jean's and refused to issue one for Sonia. Some people still managed to escape before the government set up border checkpoints. With a chatty toddler, Jean knows her family never could've gotten out. Now, she just remembers parties, game nights, newspapers, and coffee dates.

Here, Jean reveals that in addition to limiting women's means of communication, the U.S. has become a laughingstock on the world stage and no longer has positive relationships with any countries. Everyone is becoming isolated, and by destroying social bonds, the government is able to better control its populace. By barring people from leaving, the government also exerts its control over men—note that it's stopping entire families from leaving, not just women. This reminds readers that men, like women, aren't a monolith, and plenty wanted to try to save the women and girls in their lives from the counters and the ensuing oppression.



CHAPTER 3

Suddenly, Jean remembers Jackie Juarez. It's a year and a half ago, the president has recently been inaugurated, and she's watching TV with Patrick and Steven. Steven declares the woman on TV—Jackie—"hysterical," explaining that in his new AP Religious Studies class, they're learning about female hysteria. Returning to the TV, Jackie is on a talk show to promote her newest book, *They Will Shut Us Up*. The cover features pictures of dolls, all photoshopped with ball gags in their mouths. All of Jackie's books are similarly titled and have disturbing cover art. On the TV, Jackie is screaming at the interviewer for using "Feminazi," and turning to the camera, she asks female viewers to consider what it would be like to wake up and suddenly have no "voice in anything."

Patrick excuses himself to go to bed, while Steven asks to switch the channel to *Duck Dynasty*. Jean isn't impressed, but Steven scoffs that "There aren't really people like that." Steven finally goes to bed, explaining he has an AP Religious Studies test tomorrow—all students take this class, and they're cutting biology and history. Jean turns Jackie Juarez back on. Jackie looks much older than when Jean knew her in grad school 20 years ago—but Jackie looks just as accusing now as she did then.

Jean and Jackie's friendship began to go downhill when Jean once again refused to go to a march for "the Supreme Court thing," preferring instead to study for grad school. Jean tried to explain how difficult her class was, but Jackie called her a "Bubble Girl," happy to believe she was safe as a straight white woman. Following this, Jackie declined to renew her lease with Jean, and for Jean's birthday, Jackie gave Jean a gift basket filled with things that pop, like a bubble wand, sparkling wine, and gum. Jean and Jackie didn't speak again after that, but sometimes, Jean wonders if things would be different now if they'd stayed friends.

CHAPTER 4

While Patrick, Steven, Leo, and Sam sit outside and talk about their days, Jean traces letters on her palm. These days, women only get 100 words per day. All her books, even her cookbooks, are locked up away from Sonia; Patrick has the keys. Some things haven't changed, like trips to the grocery store and the hair salon (though Jean hasn't changed her cut, as it would waste words to tell her stylist what she wants). All she reads are ingredients lists, billboards, and washing instructions. On Sundays, Patrick and Jean take the kids to the movies.

Steven, as a teenage boy, is in an interesting position. At this point a year and a half ago, he's a normal kid—but he's also uniquely vulnerable to propaganda, which the AP Religious Studies class seems to impose on students. For now, this manifests as Steven dismissing Jackie Juarez's warnings that people in power will consider taking away women's voices and calling Jackie reactionary and unhinged. However, readers have the benefit of knowing that Jackie was absolutely correct—women in the novel's present are limited to 100 words per day.



The "people like that" Steven refers to are rural and conservative, and there are, in fact, plenty of rural folks who hold conservative views. This reflects the bubble Steven is in due to living in Washington, D.C. And the aside that schools are phasing out history and biology suggests that schools' goals are changing. Rather than educating students, schools are becoming a place where the government indoctrinates students—at school, students learn to obey, not to think for themselves.



With hindsight, Jean now knows that Jackie saw their horrifying present coming years ago, while Jean did not. Jackie was right that Jean relied on her privilege as a straight, white, professional woman—that is, every one of Jean's identity markers gave her and advantage and a sense of security. Because of this, she never worried about her rights and her safety. But the current situation makes it clear that these issues affect all women of all demographics, though they likely affect some more than others.



Only now does Jean share that women are limited to speaking 100 words per day. The thought is mind-boggling, as even this summary cell contains just under 100 words. This speaks to how constrained women's lives are in this present, especially since they're also mostly cut off from learning anything new. How is Jean—or any woman—supposed to learn a new recipe if she can't even have her cookbooks, or talk about it with a friend?



At first, Jean would write notes to Patrick, but she stopped when Sonia saw a lipstick note on the mirror and said, "Letters! Bad!" These days, "[w]ith Steven the way he is now," she doesn't even dare to write Patrick notes and then burn them. Listening to her husband and sons, Jean remembers Jackie telling her, "Think about what you need to do to stay free." It would've been good to do "more than fuck all."

Sonia's reaction to the note again points to how easily children adapt to situations that aren't at all normal. And as Jean then loses one way of communicating with Patrick, this breaks down their relationship. Only now does Jean realize she had the power to potentially help herself and other women, but she squandered it by not being politically active.



CHAPTER 5

Jean tells herself that this isn't Patrick's fault, though he's never been good at speaking up. The real person to blame is a man Jackie used to call Saint Carl. The president just had to listen to Reverend Carl. Jean explains how years ago, the Bible Belt started expanding until it took over the entire country. Only politically active women like Jackie saw it coming. As the years passed, the number of women elected to any office dwindled. At the last election, all of Congress was white and male. Jackie also predicted that the religious groups in power would need "an enforcement arm," and that the force would come from young, white, conservative, and angry men, as well as women invested in a more conservative social order. Jean remembers dismissing this as fearmongering. But now she has no cell phone and can't even buy postage stamps.

Jean might say she doesn't blame Patrick, but she still takes issue with his perceived inaction and, perhaps, complacency. More than men, whether men like Patrick or like Reverend Carl, Jean seems to suggest that women had the responsibility to fight and ensure their rights wouldn't be stripped away. At one point, Jean agreed with Steven in the sense that she saw Jackie as unhinged. However, she now realizes how vulnerable she and other women have always been. What's happened in the present, she suggests, should not be a surprise given how few people stood up for their rights when they still could.



CHAPTER 6

Patrick wants to have sex, so after the children are in bed, Jean agrees. As they have sex, Jean wonders if she'd be happier if Patrick were silent, too. Kissing him, she feels like she's in multiple places at once: here, having sex on prom night, giving birth to one of her children, and in a cottage two months ago with Lorenzo, whom she'd love to see again. She also thinks of her gynecologist, Dr. Claudia, and asking once if doctors are able to enjoy sex when they know exactly everything that happens in a woman's body during sex. How do other women cope with all this, and do they love their husbands—or do they hate them?

The counter puts a strain on Jean's marriage, as she now resents Patrick for the power and privilege he enjoys as a man, even if in general, he's one of the "good ones." Her wandering mind suggests she can't focus and isn't actually enjoying their intimacy—at the very least, having sex doesn't seem to be improving their relationship at all.



CHAPTER 7

Jean is dreaming and Patrick is snoring when Sonia starts screaming, “Mommy, don’t let it get me” over and over. Jean throws herself out of bed and races for Sonia’s room, passing Sam, Leo, and Steven. She feels like an awful mother as she notices the twins crying and keeps going. But Jean throws herself onto Sonia’s bed and clamps a hand over her mouth. Since Jean is out of words for today—it’s 11:30 p.m.—Patrick and the boys hurry in and soothe Sonia. Now, Jean feels useless, and she tells herself she doesn’t hate her male family members. But she does a little bit. In the living room, Jean pours herself three drinks in quick succession and waits for midnight.

Instead of going to comfort Sonia, Jean goes outside and screams, “You fucking bastards” again and again. She keeps screaming even when Patrick comes outside and begs her to stop. Lights come on at the Kings’ house next door, and Evan comes outside and threatens to call the police. Patrick finally wrestles Jean to the ground, and looking at her **counter**, he tells her she’s out of words for the day. They hear sirens coming.

The counter doesn’t differentiate between thought-out words and words shouted in a panicked time of need. So Sonia is in danger here as she screams for help, but while she does ultimately get comfort, it’s also not really comforting to be so physically quieted in a situation like this. And Jean finds herself unable to be a good parent to any of her children due to the pressures the counter puts on her. She cares more for Sonia now because Sonia could be in serious danger, while also realizing that Sam and Leo need her too—just not in the same way, as they won’t suffer physical harm for screaming after a nightmare.



Jean continues to struggle to be a present parent for her children due to the situation the “fucking bastards” (the government) have put her in. And Patrick may, in the long run, be protecting Jean by wrestling her down to stop her from yelling. But just as when Jean covered Sonia’s mouth, this is still tinged with violence and thus isn’t all that comforting.



CHAPTER 8

Today is the first day Jean hasn’t been able to tell Sonia she loves her as she walks Sonia to the school bus. And when Jean blows Sonia a kiss and Sonia blows one back, Jean looks to the camera nearby and immediately regrets it. Back when the **counters** first went on, Jean regularly saw two young moms at the grocery store together. They’d chat using rudimentary sign language—until men in uniforms took the women and their babies away. They never returned.

Once Sonia is on the bus, Jean walks back toward the house. The mailman approaches her house, greeting her politely. He insists on putting the mail in the box, per the rules, when she holds out her hand to see what he’ll do. After telling her to have a nice day, the mailman blinks three times in an exaggerated manner. He says he has a wife and three daughters, and Jean remembers that his mother, Delilah Ray, was going to be the first human to get the anti-aphasia shot Jean was working on before the **counters** went on. If it worked, Mrs. Ray was going to be able to speak coherently for the first time since she had a stroke years ago. He quietly says they’ll speak again.

Here, Jean details just how far the government is willing to go to keep women from communicating with one another. In her world, blowing one’s child kisses isn’t appropriate, and it seems women aren’t allowed basic human connections, either. Stifling their language thus destroys social bonds, both within families and in society at large. Subjecting women to such extreme social alienation makes it easier for the government to control them.



The mailman’s three blinks and his prior relationship to Jean are interesting details, though for now, they remain mostly unexplained. More importantly, Jean shares here what her work was before she lost her job: developing a cure for aphasia, or a condition that leaves a person unable to use language to communicate. While aphasia is caused by a brain injury of some sort in most cases, the government has induced a different sort of aphasia in women and girls through the counters. This continues to position Jean opposite the government: she wants everyone to be able to talk, but the government only wants to hear from a select few.



Once the mailman is gone, Olivia King, Evan's wife, heads for church. Olivia has fully bought into the new system; she was religious to begin with. Jean wasn't, so when Steven brought home his AP Religious Studies textbook, Jean was shocked to discover that the book advocated for "extreme-right fundamentalism." But when Jean asked Steven about it, he noted that his teacher had some good points, and he suggested maybe things would be better if women who "just wanna get out of the house and have some identity" stayed home to raise their kids instead. Though he insisted the class was "stupid," he refused to drop it—it would help him get into college.

Olivia's entry into the story makes the case that there are, of course, women who find immense value in Christianity, homemaking, and even the idea of separate spheres for separate genders. Jean's angst doesn't take aim at Olivia's values, but at the injustice that, all women have been forced to adhere to Olivia's values, even if they don't personally value the same things. And Steven continues to demonstrate how the Pure Movement won him over by making "good points" and by insinuating that kids—like Steven—would be happier and better off if their moms didn't work.



CHAPTER 9

Jean is watching TV. The president is giving a speech, but Jean is more interested in watching the president's wife, Anna Myers, who stands behind him. She's gorgeous and modeled swimsuits and lingerie before she married the president. Now she never smiles and wears long dresses and headscarves. She's severely depressed: Patrick has told Jean about how Anna lives in a "prison," where three Secret Service men watch her at all times and constantly check her rooms for anything she might use to try to kill herself. Jean switches the channel to golf and then, Olivia King knocks on the door, asking with gestures for a cup of sugar. Jean lets her in, annoyed at how Olivia looks disapprovingly at Jean's robe and the dirty dishes—but Olivia then smiles at Jean's **counter**.

While Jean is filled with anger and resentment due to her oppression, Anna Myers presents another potential result of restricting women's autonomy: suicidal ideation as a response to one's powerlessness. This further challenges the government's assertion that all women would be better off if they were to adhere to the same, traditional lifestyle. In fact, women are individuals with different values, interests, and priorities—it doesn't work to force all women to adhere to one lifestyle or set of values. It's impossible to tell if Olivia is smiling at the counter because she's somewhat supportive of Jean's outburst, or because she's happy that Jean can't speak more today.



Olivia's smile causes Jean to remember how, two years ago, Olivia came over to ask for some sugar and sat down to watch the talk show Jean had on. Jackie was on, wearing a red pantsuit and arguing with two women in pastels about whether women should really have to obey their husbands. The women came prepared with statistics, claiming they proved that things are way worse now than they were decades ago. Jackie wasn't able to successfully argue that their statistics were skewed. Olivia found the pastel women's argument compelling and concerning.

Jean, at least, seems unwilling to entertain the possibility that she might have anything in common with Olivia. Indeed, she seems to characterize Olivia as easily manipulated by fearmongering, at least when that fearmongering seems to align with her pre-existing beliefs.



CHAPTER 10

Olivia stays for several hours, and though Jean finds her judgmental and sanctimonious, she almost misses Olivia when she's gone. Jean begins to plan dinner, wondering if she has the recipe for biscuits memorized. She reorganizes the photos on the shelf where her cookbooks used to live, thinking of how her parents, Mamma and Papà, call from Italy most Sundays—and how Mamma can never finish the call before she starts sobbing. Just as Jean is getting dressed to go to the grocery store, Patrick pulls up outside, three government SUVs behind him.

Jean doesn't really seem to have friends anymore, so even judgy Olivia is kind of nice to have around. Jean's lack of friendships is almost certainly due to the government's attempts to break social bonds between women. Jean's inability to remember the biscuit recipe—and her inability to consult a cookbook—highlights how the Pure Movement's crackdown on women's language doesn't actually help women live out the Pure Movement's goals. Plenty of people need to follow recipes, meaning that lots of women likely aren't doing a great job of feeding their families tasty meals right now.



CHAPTER 11

Jean is certain the men are here to lecture her for last night, so she switches the channel back to CNN and returns to the kitchen. As Patrick, Reverend Carl Corbin, and five other men enter the kitchen, Jean catches bits of a breaking news story on TV: the president's brother has been in a skiing accident. The men refer to Jean as Dr. McClellan, and one man, Thomas, removes Jean's **counter**. Jean has heard enough from the TV to know what these men want, but she makes them tell her anyway: Bobby Myers has suffered a brain injury in Wernicke's area, the area she was studying before they took her job away. Reverend Carl asks Jean to join their team.

Approaching Jean for help is a sign that, despite the Pure Movement's belief that women belong at home, women can in fact be experts in science or professional fields. It also suggests that the government is far more interested in accomplishing its own goals than it is in being consistent about its messaging, highlighting again how arbitrary their guidelines are.



CHAPTER 12

Jean asks if she has a choice in this, and Reverend Carl assures her he does—he knows the thought of returning to work must be hard on her family. He explains that they've also approached Dr. Lin Kwan, the former head of Jean's department, as well. If Jean doesn't want to do this, things will “go back to normal.”

Notice Reverend Carl's phrasing: it must be hard on Jean's family to consider her return to work. With this, he reveals how little he values women's goals or opinions—there's no concern for what Jean herself wants. Carl also frames the current status quo as “normal,” when for Jean, not being able to speak or work is anything but normal.



Thanks to Steven's explanation a year ago, Jean knows that Reverend Carl genuinely thinks it is normal for women to stay home and keep house: Steven explained how men and women were fundamentally different, reading from his textbook about how women should feel happy and honored to be wives and mothers. Steven even insisted that girls, notably his crush and neighbor Julia King, thought these were good ideas. Patrick entered the kitchen then, flipped through the book, and suggested it wasn't all that bad. This was the moment Jean started hating him.

Steven presents the theory of gender essentialism to Jean, which, put simply, suggests that men and women have distinct, innate qualities. The theory has, notably, been used to justify women's oppression for millennia. Now, the Pure Movement uses it to justify confining all women to the home—while ignoring the fact that many women have interests and goals apart from being wives and mothers. And Patrick's uncritical response to the textbook suggests to Jean that he agrees with it—and by extension, doesn't support her desire to be a scientist in addition to being his wife and their children's mother.



Back in the present, Jean stalls. On the one hand, she wants to return to her work. She and Lin were so close to figuring out how to cure Wernicke's aphasia, which causes people's language to turn to gibberish. But Jean wants to help people like Mrs. Ray, not Bobby Myers.

Jean is understandably less enthusiastic about helping an architect of the current tyrannical government than she is about helping people she characterizes as innocent and deserving, like Mrs. Ray. It likely also doesn't hurt that Mrs. Ray is female, as Jean finds herself broadly resenting men due to the power the Pure Movement affords them relative to women.



CHAPTER 13

Jean invites Patrick to join her in the kitchen, ostensibly to refill the men's water glasses. Patrick encourages Jean to take the offer, but Jean insists it's blackmail. Patrick encourages her to "do it for the kids' sake." Jean thinks Steven, Sam, and Leo are fine, but she'd consider this for Sonia's sake. When they return to the living room, Reverend Carl describes the state-of-the-art lab and funding she'll get if she can find a cure in 90 days. After, her **counter** will go back on, but Reverend Carl admits that the limit will go up soon, once people are used to the counters.

Like Reverend Carl, Patrick encourages Jean to think of her children, perhaps unwittingly suggesting that what her children want or need will, in all cases, trump what Jean wants or needs. It's interesting that Reverend Carl suggests the counters' limits will increase as people get used to them—primarily because Jean has certainly changed how she speaks, but she isn't used to her counter. And she certainly isn't the only one.



Jean resents how Reverend Carl seems to characterize the **counters** as fashionable accessories, not "torture device[s]." On the day Jean and then-five-year-old Sonia got their counters, they went to an office with Patrick. The man there told Patrick to pack up all books, computers, and board games, and then he offered Jean a selection of counters in different colors. He suggested pink for Sonia, but Jean chose red for her daughter. That afternoon, Jean spoke as normal when Steven, Leo, and Sam got home—and when she hit 100 words, the electric shock knocked her over, clearly traumatizing Patrick and the boys. Sonia, though, was delighted with her counter. She seemed to kiss it.

Language is important: by not speaking about what the counters actually do, Reverend Carl tries to cast them in a less nefarious light. Jean, though, sees them as the torture devices they are. In the flashback, the man's suggestion that Sonia should get a pink counter suggests the counters can also be used to further reinforce traditional ideas of gender norms (i.e., pink is an inherently feminine color, whereas blue is an inherently masculine color). That the counters shock women when they exceed their quota reinforces Jean's assessment that they're "torture device[s]." And by traumatizing Jean's entire family, the counter ensures that Jean's male family members buy into the Pure Movement's system.



CHAPTER 14

Back in the present, once the men leave, Patrick paces. Jean notes that they won't take off Sonia's **counter**, and she asks Patrick to try to use his power as the president's science advisor to try to get Sonia's counter taken off. When he acts noncommittal, Jean slams a glass down. It shatters and cuts her hand. Washing the cut, Jean realizes she doesn't trust Reverend Carl: he's playing a game of some sort. As Patrick stitches the cut, Jean worries aloud that they're going to somehow "promote worldwide evil" with her anti-aphasia serum. Frustrated, Patrick says it might've been better when Jean didn't talk.

As someone who is suffering under a government policy she once thought would be impossible to implement, Jean doesn't think she can give the government the benefit of the doubt anymore. Why would they stop at taking away American women's voices when they could perhaps subjugate women at a global scale? Patrick's response reads as utterly naïve, and it suggests the relative privilege his gender grants him. He also illustrates how even "good" men can come to buy into this oppressive system.



CHAPTER 15

After a quiet and awkward dinner, Patrick takes bourbon to his study, leaving Jean to talk to Steven, Leo, Sam, and Sonia. Jean asks the children about their days. But Sonia seems terrified and begins crying. For readers, Jean explains that Sonia doesn't know what happens when a woman's **counter** reaches 100; Jean bribed her with sweets when Sonia didn't speak. She didn't want Sonia to "learn the hard way," or learn that the pain increases with every 10 words over 100 a woman speaks. Jean asks Sonia more yes or no questions and ascertains that Steven said something to upset her, so she sends Steven to clean up the kitchen. Steven and Sonia have always had a close relationship, so Jean is heartbroken. She puts Sonia to bed and finds Steven.

Furious, Jean confronts Steven and notices the tiny P pin on his collar. It stands for "Pure," and Steven scoffs that he earned it recently. He's chugging milk, and when Jean suggests he leaves some for everyone else, he tells her to go buy more—and she slaps him. Smugly, Steven says he's been volunteering to show how the "bracelets" work to schoolgirls. He warns her not to encourage Sonia to pick up the sign language she learned as a toddler, as the next iteration of the **counters** will be "more like gloves." He's going to help beta test them, because he's a "Pure M[a]n." Jean calls him a bastard.

In order to protect Sonia from physical pain, Jean has, in a way, helped the Pure Movement achieve its aims: Sonia seems increasingly less talkative, as she has spent one of her six years alive in a world where being quiet earns her praise. This points both to young children's ability to adapt to horrible situations, and to how the government is forcing Jean to compromise her morals and her parenting philosophy in order to protect her daughter to the best of her ability.



In addition to learning that Sonia has lost her innocence (she now knows what the counters do), Jean learns how deeply Steven now believes in the Pure Movement's ideals. As his rudeness to Jean over the milk shows, the Pure Movement has taught Steven to become selfish—he no longer sees it as his responsibility to think of others, as by making sure there's enough milk for the rest of his family or buying more himself. Rather, his loyalty now is to the Pure Movement. This puts him in direct opposition to his own mother, which in turn causes Jean to again make awful decisions she'll later regret, as when she hits Steven.



CHAPTER 16

After reading Sonia a story, Jean goes to her bedroom and thinks that she doesn't hate Steven. He genuinely believes in something wrong. But Jean does hate some men. For instance, the misogynistic and hateful men like Dr. Claudia's husband, who told Jean once that women got the **counters** because they "need to be taught a lesson." Or Evan, who beats Julia. Patrick is the third kind of man: "weak." So, Jean lets herself think about Lorenzo. She last saw him two months ago, when they met to have sex. He's probably back in Italy now, where he's also from. As Jean gets up and makes coffee, she remembers how they met at work. They'd make coffee, talk, and laugh in Italian. Then, one day, he brought her a music box, and that's the day Jean decided she wanted to have sex with him.

In this chapter, Jean sorts men into three categories. The true believers like Steven aren't a problem, in her estimation, because they don't have malicious intentions (though given Steven's cruelty to Jean and the implication that he's becoming drunk on power, this is debatable). Jean takes more issue with men who wish to put women in their place—or men who, like Patrick, don't want women to be subjugated but also are too afraid to do or say anything. It's Patrick's weakness that makes Lorenzo so attractive to Jean: where Patrick's devotion to Jean seems passive and noncommittal, Lorenzo is pretty clear about wanting to be in a relationship with Jean.



CHAPTER 17

Steven leaves early the next morning, the twins are unusually quiet, and Sonia is still sad and silent. Jean walks her to the bus stop, unsure of how to even talk to her daughter now that she can. As Sonia boards the bus, Jean imagines her at school. Rather than learning to read and write, and passing notes about boys, girls now learn basic math and how to tell time. Jean attended the school's open house in the fall to see the "state-of-the-art" home economics facilities. Sonia, Jean realizes, has it good in a way, as she doesn't remember how things were before.

Jean makes her choice. Getting back home, she sees Patrick watching Reverend Carl on TV, talking about how they found Dr. Jean McClellan to cure Bobby Myers's Wernicke's aphasia. She turns the TV off and tells Patrick to call the president and say she won't do it. He begs her to change her mind, and Jean wonders if she's ever loved her husband.

Even Jean is beginning to adapt to the new normal when she suggests that perhaps Sonia's lack of awareness of the pre-Pure Movement world actually its advantages. She recognizes that Sonia has adapted to the Pure Movement's ideas and is, in that sense, safe. This isn't to say that Jean doesn't think that the Pure Movement will limit Sonia's life due to her gender—Jean values education and literacy too much to go that far. But she nevertheless realizes that Sonia's misguided belief that her life is normal and okay will alleviate some of Sonia's suffering and bitterness. Jean, in contrast, remembers how life was before and therefore cannot accept her life as it is today.



Unlike Patrick, Jean isn't willing to cooperate with her oppressors. She does now what her flashbacks of Jackie have suggested she should've done some time ago: stand up for what she believes in, particularly women's rights.



CHAPTER 18

Reverend Carl returns to the McClellan house alone. Jean notices the buttons on his suit sleeves—"kissing buttons," like Lorenzo used to have on his suits, and which resulted in his and Jean's first kiss when she commented on them. Reverend Carl asks Jean to reconsider, even offering to up Sonia's quota, but Jean refuses. So he pulls a **counter** out of a box, but it's not Jean's old one: this one has a "courtesy tracker," which will reduce her word limit each time she curses. It also requires Jean to recite from a script daily, which won't count against her quota.

The first line states that man was created in God's image, and that woman was "made from man." Jean refuses to read further, so Reverend Carl threatens to have Thomas come finish this later. Jean has known of Thomas for a year now—he's one of the men who rounded up women at the talk Jean was giving on the last day she worked. He tased Lin and wouldn't let anyone help her. Remembering this, Jean continues to read about how women should be silent and obey men, be modest and "glorify man, therefore glorifying God" by being submissive. Patrick's face is white. Reverend Carl asks Patrick to put the **counter** on Jean's wrist, and Patrick complies.

Jean's previous tracker allowed her to use her words however she liked, including to curse or say things that don't align with the Pure Movement's ideology. Now, they're taking things a step further by policing what women can say, in addition to how much they can say.



The script that Jean (and, it's implied, other women in the future) will have to read is an attempt at brainwashing women. These pro-Pure Movement words will become most of what women say all day, the hope being that by repeating these ideas, women will come to genuinely believe and accept them as doctrine. By forcing Patrick to put the counter on Jean's wrist, Reverend Carl continues to sow strife in Jean and Patrick's marriage. It reinforces the uneven power dynamic between them, and while Patrick doesn't really want to be in charge of his wife, he also (disappointingly) doesn't decline to participate in this show of his and the Pure Movement's power.



CHAPTER 19

Jean hurries to the door that afternoon to collect Sonia from the bus. Sonia flings herself into Jean's arms. She squeals "Won prize!" and points to what looks like dried ice cream on her face. Jean grabs her hand—she doesn't want the cameras, or Steven, to see Sonia gesturing. Sonia has a sealed envelope addressed to Patrick. Dying to know what Sonia won, Jean fixes her hot chocolate as Sonia says, proudly, "Lowest." Jean checks Sonia's **counter**, suddenly hating the men who designed them. Enraged, Jean leaves the room until Patrick gets home and can tell her what's in the letter. She already knows, though: Sonia's counter read three words, meaning Sonia said nothing until she got home from school.

Everything and everyone around Sonia is telling her that it's a good thing to be silent. Through mostly positive reinforcement, Sonia is losing her ability to express herself—or stand up for herself. It's also telling that Jean is afraid to allow Sonia to point to her face. This continues to develop the idea that Jean is forced to buy into the system to protect her family. And by outlawing even nonverbal communication, the government seeks to further isolate women.



CHAPTER 20

Patrick reads the letter aloud, and it's exactly what Jean expected: the school is launching daily, and later monthly, contests to see who can speak the least. For some reason, Patrick is smiling. He offers Jean a letter from his briefcase—a letter from the president. Just then, Steven, Leo, and Sam get home, and Steven compliments Jean's new **counter**. Julia just got one, too. Patrick urges Jean to open the letter, and finally, she does. It's one sentence: "Please call me with your price." Jean steps outside. She wants to turn back time and erase the Pure Movement, but the president won't go for that.

To Jean, it feels like a betrayal that Patrick is so excited about the letter from the president and also that he's so nonchalant about Sonia's win. He seems to be totally on board with his daughter's silence and his wife's complicity in her own (and other women's) oppression.



Sonia comes out to join Jean and offers her a picture she drew. It's a picture of their family, but Jean is portrayed as smaller than Patrick, Steven, Sam, or Leo—she's only bigger than Sonia herself. Hugging Sonia, Jean realizes that Jackie was right all those years ago about how Jean lived in a bubble. Jean begins to mentally draft her response to President Myers with the 63 words she has left today.

Sonia's picture shows Jean what the Pure Movement has done: it's made women small and powerless. Jean genuinely does have less power than even her 11-year-old sons, simply by virtue of being female. Thus, Jean decides to negotiate with the president to see if she can resist, even in a small way, and change Sonia's implied beliefs about women's inferiority.



CHAPTER 21

While the kids watch TV in the next room and Patrick watches, Jean dials the White House and asks for Sonia's **counter** to be removed and for her to be excused from school, and for Lin to join the project. To her surprise, President Myers agrees. Patrick gets a call moments later; Thomas will arrive soon to take off Jean and Sonia's counters. Jean begins to cook dinner, thinking that she's an awful mother for how she trained Sonia to believe she should be silent. Jean tells herself that none of this is her fault—she didn't vote for Myers. But Jean didn't vote at all, and she remembers Jackie accusing her of being willfully uninformed. Unsurprisingly, Jackie hated Patrick for being weak, too. It was around the time that Jean started dating Patrick that she discovered Jackie was a lesbian.

As Jean's fortunes begin to change, she suddenly has a new perspective on how she's parented Sonia thus far. While she encouraged Sonia to be silent for Sonia's safety, Jean also knows that it's not good for a child's development to not speak. So, getting the counter removed is, in some ways, a test of how quickly Sonia can adapt—if she can adapt. Jean blames herself for the present situation, as she realizes only now that she had a responsibility to at least vote for candidates she supported. Instead, Jean escaped into a relationship with Patrick, seeing him as a refuge and their relationship as totally distinct from whatever might be going on in politics.



Patrick brings Jean back to the present by asking her what she's thinking about. Jean is wondering if Jackie ended up in what Reverend Carl calls a "camp," which is actually a prison: the government imprisons LGBTQIA people, putting gay men and lesbians in cells together until they agree to marry. Jean says nothing, though. Patrick kisses her and says that soon, things will "be back to normal." Jean isn't convinced.

The prisons for gay people are horrifying. In this context, they remind Jean that society stopped being "normal" some time ago—her being able to speak again doesn't change the fact that no other women in the U.S. currently has the privilege, nor does it change the fact that Jackie and other gay people are imprisoned in horrifying conditions.



CHAPTER 22

Sonia bites Thomas when he comes to take her **counter** off, and then she refuses to come to dinner. Jean promises Sonia that she won't have to attend school now—she can watch cartoons at Olivia's house while Jean works. But Sonia wails that she "was going to win tomorrow" and then refuses to speak. Jean joins the rest of the family at the table, where Steven cruelly notes that they still don't have milk and asks how Jean plans to work and homeschool Sonia. Though Patrick reprimands Steven, Steven tells Patrick that Patrick is hopelessly out of step. He describes how he's been talking with Evan about marrying Julia as part of a Department of Health and Welfare program, which promises to compensate boys who marry before 18 and pay out bonuses for every child they have.

Disturbingly, Sonia has clearly begun to adapt to life with the counter. Not speaking earns her praise and rewards at school—and so even though being able to speak freely again is arguably a good thing, Sonia doesn't see it that way. Steven, meanwhile, has bought into the Pure Movement more and more. Here, he articulates one reason for this: it promises to reward him for his cooperation. By marrying Julia and having children with her, he gets enough money to live comfortably. Put simply, it benefits him, and he's been encouraged to dehumanize and devalue women and their desires or experiences—as evidenced by his cruelty toward Jean.



Steven looks confused when Jean asks what Julia thinks of this. He also insists that Jean gets no say; Patrick gets to make the call. Jean wonders if this is how "kids turn into monsters." It only takes one generation to turn everything upside down. Disgusted, Jean gets up to try to call her parents.

The Pure Movement wants to put men in charge, so it follows that neither Julia nor Jean get to have an opinion on whether Steven can marry Julia. As far as Jean is concerned, Steven's new indifference to women's thoughts or experiences makes him a "monster."



CHAPTER 23

For the first time in a year, Jean dresses in a suit. She's barely ready when Morgan, who's young, smug, and incapable, knocks on the door so Jean can sign paperwork. He obnoxiously refers to "his" team and project. Jean signs the paperwork without looking at it—the government will do what it wants no matter what she signs—and Patrick signs the forms so her paychecks will go to his account. Jean thinks of Sonia and how happy she looked to go with Olivia earlier—perhaps because of the promised cartoons, but maybe because Olivia still wears a **counter**. Once Jean has perused the compensation form, Morgan checks her fingerprints and Patrick unlocks Jean's laptop. Then, Morgan shows Jean a list of the team. Morgan is team leader; Jean and Lin are next. Jean feels like she's been punched when she sees Lorenzo's name after hers.

While Jean makes it clear that Morgan has been full of himself for a long time, the Pure Movement's takeover means that Morgan is even more drunk on power than he might've been when women still had basic rights. Like Steven, Morgan has been given incentive to buy into the movement—it means he doesn't have to be at all competent to be in charge. Sonia's difficulty adjusting highlights how fully she's adjusted to her new normal. It's unsettling for her to suddenly be able to use her voice and to hear her mom speak freely. Olivia, by contrast, is safe and comforting.



CHAPTER 24

Jean takes the time to boot up her laptop and go through a few files she doesn't want to share with Morgan before following him to the lab. Jean finds the folder she marked with an X and hides it in the sleeper sofa in Patrick's office. It contains the key for how to reverse Wernicke's aphasia, and Jean is the only one who knows how close she was. Last spring, she presented a lecture in which she detailed the exact location a serum would need to be injected to cure Wernicke's aphasia. Around the same time, Lorenzo pulled Jean into his office for a passionate kiss and then showed her his research identifying the protein to inject into the brain. Jean then heads to her car to follow Morgan.

Jean is fully invested in finding a cure for Wernicke's aphasia, but she's not interested in just handing over her nearly completed research when it will only benefit Bobby Myers. That is, Jean understands that if she wants to actually have any time without her counter (and for Sonia to relearn how to speak without hers), she'll need to stall on the information she shares with readers here.



CHAPTER 25

Morgan drops Jean off in her office and soon, Lin walks in. Lin is a neurolinguist and surgeon who left her surgery practice in her late 40s to get a dual doctorate in cognitive science and linguistics. The women hug, and then Lin says she was close to being able to get to Malaysia. They discuss the latest **counters** and that they'll have counters put back on when they're done. Jean notes that they can stall, and she suggests that maybe they reverse their serum and use it on everyone in the White House. Then, they head for Lorenzo's office for coffee.

The novel details both Jean's and Lin's extensive educations in part to make it clear that they're extremely competent—unlike Morgan. And their relative competence has nothing to do with their respective genders—Morgan simply hasn't worked as hard as his female colleagues and has no interest in doing so. Nevertheless, he holds a higher position than them—solely because of his gender.



CHAPTER 26

Lorenzo's office is bigger and has a window, which angers Jean. Lin shoves Jean inside and runs off—and Jean nearly faints as she tries to greet Lorenzo. But rather than rushing into his arms and having passionate sex, she vomits into his trash can and excuses herself to the restroom. After vomiting more, Jean realizes she hasn't had a period recently. She's 43, the mother of four, and is pregnant—hopefully not with a girl.

While becoming unexpectedly pregnant during an affair would be huge news in any context, being pregnant in this time and place is extremely fraught. Jean, for instance, immediately leaps to hoping her baby isn't a girl—she doesn't want to bring a girl into a world where that child will never learn how to speak.



CHAPTER 27

Lin is waiting outside the bathroom. She walks Jean to their office and assures her that while she's well aware that Jean and Lorenzo are in love, Morgan is too self-absorbed to notice. As Lin asks how long the affair has been going on, Jean thinks back to the cottage on the bay. Jean and Lorenzo only met once after the Pure Movement took over. They ran into each other at a market stall, and Lorenzo asked Jean to meet him in an alley. In addition to premarital and extramarital sex being illegal, the Pure Movement has done away with birth control.

Here, Jean helps readers understand exactly how much trouble she's in: having sex with Lorenzo was illegal. Criminalizing extramarital sex and abolishing birth control are two ways that the Pure Movement exerts control over women by depriving them of any reliable way to plan their families.



Jean remembers how one of her neighbors, Annie Wilson, was arrested for meeting her lover every week after her husband went to work. Annie had planned to leave her husband, but she couldn't once the Pure Movement took over. When her husband reported her crime, she was taken away. Jean watched Annie on TV, in a long dress with shaved hair, as Reverend Carl shamed her and said she couldn't speak at all now. Despite knowing what could happen, Jean chose to meet Lorenzo that day because she knew that unmarried women were pushed into (still not legal, but tolerated) sex work if they chose not to marry. Sex with him felt like a form of protest, and a way to protect Sonia from one day being forced into sex work.

Annie is an example of the worst-case consequence for Jean. Her fate highlights the Pure Movement's interest in publicly shaming women to send a message to others that the government can and will punish them for stepping out of line. Still, this situation pushed Jean to feel even more strongly about breaking the rules and having sex with Lorenzo. Her logic may be flawed—having an affair isn't going to protect Sonia—but with no good options, it seemed like the only way for Jean to exercise some agency over her own life and, in so doing, set a positive example for her daughter.



CHAPTER 28

Morgan leads Jean, Lin, and Lorenzo to the security office. On the way, he announces that there is a deadline: President Myers needs his brother at the end of June to accompany him to the G20 summit. Jean is incredulous, especially when Morgan says this was, in fact, in her contract. At the security office, Morgan asks a middle-aged man wearing the Pure pin for key cards. Jean again imagines Sonia engaging in sex work as she, Lin, and Lorenzo get their photos taken and receive ID cards. The guard shakes Morgan's hand and offers a hand to Lorenzo—but Lorenzo declines, explaining that "[s]omething might rub off on [him]." Jean loves Lorenzo because he stands up to injustices, unlike Patrick.

Jean fixates on Sonia and what Sonia's future might be like given the current political landscape in the United States. If nothing changes, Sonia's options are to marry (possibly against her will, judging by Steven's conversations with Evan about marrying Julia) or engage in sex work. Jean recognizes that this isn't really a choice at all—either way, Sonia will be pushed into serving men. Given the current political climate, Jean also finds herself comparing Patrick and Lorenzo in a way she might not have otherwise. It's the external factors that make Lorenzo look particularly attractive.



Morgan takes the team to a conference room where, soon, a huge but creepily quiet man joins them and introduces himself as Mr. Poe. Poe explains that all work (including their laptops) must stay at the lab, and they can't socialize with anyone else. Interestingly, he refers to Jean, Lin, and Lorenzo as "part of the team," but Morgan corrects him that they *are* the team. Poe finishes his spiel and then leaves. Morgan leads the team to tour the lab.

It already seems likely that Morgan (and/or the government) is keeping secrets from Jean, Lin, and Lorenzo, as evidenced by the slip that they're "part of the team." The project is, perhaps, much bigger than just curing Bobby Myers's Wernicke's aphasia.



CHAPTER 29

Morgan invites Jean to try her card to unlock the lab. The lab is outfitted with mice (which have always made Jean squeamish) and rabbits. Through the next door is a collection of expensive imaging equipment, including multiple types of ultrasound, two MRI machines, and a PET machine. Morgan gestures toward the biochemistry lab and other equipment. There's no internet, but they have access to basic computer programs and extensive academic databases. Morgan then leaves Jean, Lin, and Lorenzo alone in the lab. Thanks to their experiences trying (and failing) to secure funding for their research in the past, they know that this lab cost at least 25 million dollars, and they can tell it's been here longer than Bobby Myers has been injured.

All signs point to the project being much bigger than what Jean, Lin, and Lorenzo are ostensibly supposed to work on—after their own experiences trying to secure funding and equipment, they know full well that the lab equipment has been here for more than a few days. The government either fully underestimates the scientists' knowledge, or it believes it's powerful enough to do whatever it likes without threat of facing any consequences.



CHAPTER 30

Lin gives Jean a meaningful look and then leaves Lorenzo and Jean alone. Mouthing “bugs,” Lorenzo turns on a sink full blast and pulls out a sheet of paper, which they pretend to study. He explains that he promised Morgan they could finish this in a month to get Jean and Lin on the team, and he needs the \$100,000 promised bonus for a “very personal matter.” They discuss that this lab has been here longer than the three days that Bobby Myers has been hospitalized, and that their first subject should be Delilah Ray. Privately, Jean thinks of Mrs. Ray’s son, her mailman who blinked meaningfully and said that he has a wife and three daughters.

What Lorenzo plans to use the bonus money for remains a mystery for now. The fact that Lorenzo was able to negotiate with Morgan to bring Lin and Jean on the team highlights his power as a man in the novel’s world. Jean and Lin, on the other hand, had little agency in the matter. As Jean continues to think about her mailman, she seems to pick up on the possibility that he might be harboring secrets. While Jean has seen that being married with a daughter hasn’t made all men sympathetic to women’s situations—Evan still beats Julia, for instance—perhaps, for the mailman, it has.



CHAPTER 31

As Jean drives home, she remembers Jackie insulting Patrick for being weak. Jackie was so disappointed in Jean’s choice to marry Patrick that she didn’t come to the wedding, but Jean knows Jackie would never insult Lorenzo. When Jean stops at a light, the man in the car next to her gestures for her to roll her window down—and then spits into her car. Lorenzo would beat the man (as would Jackie), but Patrick wouldn’t. Jean knows Jackie is currently in a conversion camp where she performs forced labor and can’t speak at all. She remembers Steven insisting sexuality was a choice, and given the promising statistics, the camps are working. Jackie would never give in, and Jean didn’t think Lorenzo would either. But for some reason, he did when he agreed to work on the aphasia project—and Jean believes it has to do with her.

With years’ worth of hindsight, Jean sees Jackie as someone she should’ve listened to and emulated. She believes now that marrying Patrick wasn’t a good choice, given his seeming unwillingness to defend his wife or stand up to injustice. Interestingly, though, Jean seems to elevate those who are willing to take a stand and protest, something she herself isn’t really doing. This suggests, however, that she may start to rebel more as the novel progresses. It’s worth noting that conversion therapy is considered pseudoscience. Moreover, studies have shown it to be ineffective and even harmful. The Pure Movement’s choice to embrace this controversial treatment, then, speaks to their willingness to prioritize their own agenda not just above people’s happiness, but also over what science suggests is actually possible (and humane) to do.



CHAPTER 32

When Jean gets home, Patrick is cooking, the younger kids are playing cards, and Steven is next door talking to Julia. Patrick agrees to speak to Steven about “this marriage thing,” and then he sends Jean to his office to FaceTime her parents, who called earlier. Mamma has been experiencing headaches but scoffs when Jean suggests she stop smoking. She asks if Jean will visit this summer, so she doesn’t die alone. Jean is disturbed. Once she gets off the call, she notices a **manila envelope** labeled top secret, with a presidential P in the corner. Unable to help herself, Jean opens it. It reveals that there are three teams on the Wernicke’s aphasia project, Gold, Red, and White. Jean’s team is the white team. Before Jean can investigate further, Sonia bursts in with news that she won at cards. She tells Jean she loves her.

Patrick continues to speak and act as though he’s not all that bothered by the Pure Movement’s actions. Referring to Steven wanting to marrying Julia—possibly against Julia’s will—as “this marriage thing” comes off as dismissive and unconcerned. Meanwhile, the official manila envelope (and the information it contains) reveals that Patrick likely knows way more about what Jean is supposed to be doing at work than Jean does. It suggests his complicity, too—something that further damages his and Jean’s relationship.



CHAPTER 33

Jean has always been a terrible liar, but she manages to tell Patrick everything is fine with her parents. She tastes the pasta sauce and says it's good, but everything tastes awful. Just then, Steven gets home, looking flushed and upset, and heads straight for his room. Jean goes to talk to him to escape the kitchen smells. At first, Steven insists he's fine, but then he asks if she'd tell on someone she loves if they did something bad. In earlier circumstances, Jean would say yes, but she also knows that reporting a parent who hits their child is different from reporting that Lin dates women. She says it depends, wondering if Steven could possibly know about Lorenzo.

It's impossible to know exactly what Steven is referring to when he asks this of Jean, but Jean's guilty conscience means that she immediately worries Steven knows she's conducting an affair (which is illegal). In her thoughts on the matter and in what she tells Steven, she rejects black-and-white thinking in favor of nuance. This, notably, goes against what the Pure Movement promotes, which is that there's only one correct way to act, think, and be—and anyone who tries to forge their own path is incorrect and immoral.



CHAPTER 34

When police sirens and lights wake Jean in the middle of the night, she's terrified that Steven reported her and Lorenzo. Multiple police cars and a box van block her driveway, and Jean envisions Poe arresting her and getting sent to work in Iowa after being publicly shamed. Patrick goes to the door, while Sonia runs in and climbs into Jean's arms.

Jean continues to fixate on her belief that Steven reported her for her affair. This speaks to her guilty conscience and of the high stakes in the affair. And in this moment of fear, Jean clings to Sonia, the child she now worries about more than her sons thanks to the government's oppressive and anti-woman policies.



CHAPTER 35

Five minutes later, nothing has happened at the McClellan house—the police aren't here for Jean. Jean carries Sonia to the kitchen and hears Olivia scream next door. Then, she realizes that the men are here for Julia, not Olivia. Olivia is screaming at Evan to do something, and she continues even as her **counter** begins to shock her. Jean races outside, barefoot, and tells the men to take Olivia's counter off, but one man just tells Julia to get in the van while another threatens to tase Jean. Jean wishes she could unsee Patrick standing on their porch, doing nothing. Steven also appears to watch Julia be taken away, his eyes glassy.

The scene next door impresses upon readers that even among women who believe in the Pure Movement's ideals, there are limits. Olivia doesn't want to see her daughter taken away for (as Steven said earlier) "doing something bad," and she's more than willing to use her voice despite the pain to try to protect her child. Evan and Patrick, however, respond with disturbingly similar passivity. It's troubling that despite the relative safety and power their gender affords them, neither seems willing to help.



After sending Sonia, Sam, and Leo to bed, Jean demands Steven tell her what happened. He seems like a scared kid as he admits that he and Julia kissed, and "it wasn't supposed to happen." Jean asks if Patrick can pull strings with Reverend Carl or President Myers, but he insists he's powerless, even when Jean suggests they say that Steven assaulted Julia and it wasn't her fault. Steven quips that that would be a lie, but he doesn't answer when Jean asks if he knows what's going to happen to Julia. Jean remembers Julia skating down the street in a halter top. After her public shaming on TV, she'll spend the rest of her life silently performing backbreaking labor. And the men in her life can do nothing to save her.

Steven implies that he and Julia had consensual sex and that he then reported her. The fact that Julia suffers punishment while Steven does not highlights the huge gender imbalance the Pure Movement has set up. It also points to the movement's gender essentialist ideas (in this case, that it's fine and expected for men to want and have sex with multiple women, whereas women who want sex outside of marriage are sexually deviant).



CHAPTER 36

Jean is supposed to get Fridays off, but she's too worked up to stay home. She remembers Jackie encouraging her to attend rallies and do other small things to protect women's rights, but Jean—and Patrick—sneered. Unable to stand the smell of coffee, Jean makes herself breakfast as Sonia comes into the kitchen, full of questions about Julia. Figuring she'll need a different babysitter for Sonia today, Jean decides to wait for the mailman and see if he can help. Whatever she does today, Jean isn't going to watch Julia's televised shaming—but when Steven comes down and asks to stay home from school, she insists he go. Jean knows his school will make students watch, and he needs to see it.

Steven answers the phone and passes it to Jean; it's Papà. He's crying. A doctor takes the phone from him and explains to Jean that Mamma had a brain aneurysm. It burst in Wernicke's area. The doctor has to go, but he tells Jean that Mamma isn't conscious, and he'll call with more information later. Jean remembers Jackie telling her to "start small"—but Jean knows she has to do something massive.

Jean realizes that what happened to Julia shouldn't surprise her: in fact, Jean and many others didn't fight to protect their rights while they had the chance. Now, they are reaping the consequences of their inaction. Given how little power she has now, Jean's only real method of punishing Steven for reporting Julia is to make sure he sees exactly what he did to her. She recognizes that Steven cares for Julia and that seeing someone he loves publicly shamed is going to be difficult for him—thus, in order to (hopefully) help him develop some empathy, he needs to see the suffering he caused.



Suddenly, everything has become personal to Jean: her work could save her own mother, and people she loves are being swept away by the Pure Movement. She realizes now that she must find some way to protest and, hopefully, protect those she loves—and potentially help other women, too.



CHAPTER 37

Later, Jean meets the mailman and explains that she's back at work and will need test subjects. The mailman is happy Mrs. Ray might get her speech back, though he laments that she'll then have to wear a **counter**. Jean watches him remove outgoing mail from the box with a key that matches Patrick's before putting more mail inside. He calls his wife, Sharon, to ask her about babysitting Sonia, and Sharon agrees. He asks Jean to tell Sharon he'll be working late and then scribbles his address on an advertisement. Jean takes it without looking.

Inside the house, Jean tries to turn Sonia's cartoon off, but she's too late. Julia is on the screen in a long smock, her hair shaved. Reverend Carl begins reciting from the Pure Movement's manifesto. Sonia asks if the girl is Julia, but Jean lies that it isn't. After turning the TV off, Jean looks at the mailman's scrap of paper. It reads, "Don't be too surprised" after the address.

This passage sets up several important ideas and details, namely that at least on the surface, the mailman thinks it's perfectly fine—even good—that women like Jean and his mother are able to talk. This cuts against what the Pure Movement wants. Additionally, it's notable that the mailman's key matches Patrick's, though this is a detail the novel won't return to until later.



Publicly shaming girls and women like Julia, who step out of line, is one way the government flaunts its power. Through Reverend Carl, it can say what it wants about Julia and women and girls like her—and Julia isn't able to defend herself at all.



CHAPTER 38

The driveway up to the Ray house is dirt and rutted, running alongside a huge vegetable garden and a Jeep whose plates read “IMPURE.” Sharon Ray steps onto the porch, looking like a middle-aged and Black Rosie the Riveter. She motions Jean and Sonia into the barn and introduces them to her horses, explaining that her **counter**, and her daughters’ counters, are fake. Del, her husband, figured out how to take real ones off. She resumes telling Sonia about the horses and then tells Jean that Del is an engineer. She shows Jean his workshop and explains to Jean, who’s embarrassed, that she and Del believe it’s only a matter of time before the Pure Movement decides to take issue with interracial marriages.

Jean and Sharon exchange numbers so they can set up Mrs. Ray’s appointment later, and Sharon asks Jean to say nothing about their conversation—Del is the “errand boy for the resistance,” so he could get in a lot of trouble. Jean is relieved to hear there’s a resistance at all, but Sharon just scoffs. Jean is reminded of Jackie as she leaves for her doctor’s appointment.

Del and Sharon are obviously against the Pure Movement, as evidenced first by the vanity plates. Sharon makes it clear to Jean that it’s absolutely necessary to take risks and work to protect vulnerable groups, as the Pure Movement’s real goal, she suggests, is to put white men in charge. It’s also a huge revelation for readers, if not for Jean, that Del, a mailman and therefore a public employee, is against the government. This suggests not just that there are likely more people out there resisting, but that they’re also likely hiding in plain sight by seeming to buy into the status quo.



Sharon confirms that Del isn’t working alone—he’s part of a larger group. Jean’s relief at hearing there’s a resistance may reflect her earlier belief that lots of people have just given up and accepted the new normal. Learning that some people haven’t is galvanizing.



CHAPTER 39

The gynecologist, Dr. Mendoza, tells Jean she’s about 10 weeks pregnant and, despite her age, should have a healthy baby in December. Jean doesn’t even ask what will happen if she doesn’t want this baby—and she *doesn’t* want it, especially if it’s a girl. He gives Jean an envelope for Patrick containing important information and then schedules her for a test next Monday to find out the sex. As soon as Dr. Mendoza leaves, Jean dresses and hurries out, struggling to breathe. She considers smoking heavily to try to induce an abortion. No parent wants to choose a wrist counter for a three-month-old.

Jean makes it clear that she doesn’t want to be pregnant or have another baby now, under these circumstances. But she can’t make that choice due to the restrictions the Pure Movement has put on women’s autonomy. This lack of choice pushes her to consider extreme options, such as smoking to induce a miscarriage, all to avoid having to make choices later that she knows would end up hurting her baby, such as putting a wrist counter on an infant and denying that child the ability to ever learn to speak. There are, in short, no good options here—all because the Pure Movement has taken away most options.



CHAPTER 40

At the lab, Jean ushers Lin and Lorenzo into the MRI room and turns the machine on—the noise is deafening, so they can speak (or yell) in private. Jean tells them about Mamma and the three teams she learned about from Patrick’s **envelope**. They discuss bringing Mrs. Ray in on Monday or Tuesday after Lin works on mice over the weekend. Asking Lin for a moment alone with Lorenzo, Jean tries to tell him she’s pregnant. After searching the room for cameras, Lorenzo pulls Jean into a kiss and asks if the baby is his. After another kiss, Lorenzo promises Jean that he’s “working on it.” Does he have a way out? If he does, can Sonia come? And what will Patrick and Steven say? Jean can hear Jackie saying, “I told you so.”

Thanks to her snooping through Patrick’s files, Jean can now lean on her coworkers to get to the bottom of what the government is really planning. As Jean shares the news of her pregnancy with Lorenzo and infers that he’s trying to get her out of the country, Jean is faced with yet more impossible choices that won’t allow her to genuinely be happy or feel like a good parent. Either way, she believes she’ll end up abandoning or harming at least some of her children. And recalling Jackie’s warning suggests that Jean believes she should’ve seen long ago that this is an expected consequence of years of apathy.



CHAPTER 41

Lin reappears, turns the MRI off, and explains that Poe is here—and he snuck in silently. Out in the rest of the lab, Poe asks why the MRI machine was on at all and pokes around the lab. He then tells Jean that Morgan wants to see her and escorts her up to Morgan's office on the fifth floor, where most of the other offices seem to belong to military men and doctors. Morgan immediately asks Jean where she was this morning, but he won't let her explain. He launches into a tirade about this being why "the old way didn't work," since women have sick kids or periods. Women aren't dependable, and things were great in the 1950s. He assures her she'll get used to her subjugation when she's done being angry—and he informs her that he changed her contract, and she no longer has Fridays off.

Morgan also says they're moving up the deadline a week, though he refuses to tell Jean why. He seems incredulous that they'll be running a human trial on Monday after working through the weekend. When Morgan dismisses her, Jean drops her purse so she can peek at the binder he's trying to hide from her. The well-worn spine reads "PROJECT WERNICKE."

Morgan seems to speak for many men who are now in charge of the government when he insists that women are unsuited for work outside the home due to normal body functions, like menstruation, or the fact that they're parents. (This second fact assumes that mothers, not fathers, are the primary parent in all cases. It also assumes that a man would never need to leave work to take care of a child.) Suggesting that Jean will just get used to her life as an unwilling housewife also suggests that Morgan doesn't see women as full people, with dreams or desires beyond performing work that, per the Pure Movement, best suits them.



Morgan's choice to move the deadline when he doesn't expect his subordinates to be able to meet it points to his power-hungry nature. It becomes increasingly clear that Jean, Lin, and Lorenzo are part of a much bigger project—Project Wernicke—and that they don't know what exactly the project entails.



CHAPTER 42

Poe escorts Jean back to her lab. On the way, Jean makes note of security measures and thinks about how odd—and concerning—it is that Morgan had a single, well-worn Project Wernicke binder, when Jean's team's research alone would fill 100 binders. She realizes again that her lab equipment has been here for some time, suggesting this project has also been in the works for a while. When the elevator reaches Jean's floor, she trips on the way out. Poe pulls her up and warns her to be careful, and when Poe disappears, Lorenzo appears behind Jean and hugs her.

Poe continues to come across as a dangerous and intimidating foe. He stands in stark contrast to Lorenzo, who not only wants to protect Jean but who also sees her as a full person in her own right. As Jean connects the dots, she becomes increasingly frightened of what the government might be planning to do with her work.



CHAPTER 43

Too afraid to turn on the MRI machine again, Jean pretends to be sick so Lin and Lorenzo can escort her out to her car. Guards search them at the door. Outside, Jean bends over like she's trying to catch her breath and explains that the projects are color-coded. Lin suggests Jean try to sneak into Patrick's office to find out more. Lorenzo helps Jean the rest of the way to the car, and they discuss Jean telling Patrick about her pregnancy. Jean knows Patrick will be well aware the baby isn't his, though he won't tell on her to protect their children. Lorenzo tells Jean that he's working on something else, and he'll know more by Monday. Before they can say more, Poe appears in front of Jean's car. Jean backs the car out, terrified of Poe.

Now, Jean and her team seem to fully believe that what's far more important than developing a cure for Wernicke's aphasia is figuring out what the government is trying to do with their research—and stopping that plan from happening, if possible. They're gradually shifting to prioritizing direct action above theoretical resistance, and their behavior here suggests they all now understand the importance of appearing as though they're following along. Meanwhile, Patrick begins to look more and more like Jean's enemy—it seems as though he's conspiring to use her work for something nefarious.



CHAPTER 44

On the way home from the Rays' farm, Sonia chatters on and on about her time on the farm. Jean wants to ask Del if he'd replace her and Sonia's **counters** with fakes, but she fears what Steven might do, or that Sam or Leo might slip up and tell someone. She thinks about Morgan speaking so fondly of the 1950s, and of how nobody thought this would happen until President Myers was elected. Even Jean got involved in protests then. The protesters had hoped the Supreme Court would be able to rein in President Myers and his top advisors, his brother Bobby and Reverend Carl, but it's been over two years now and nothing has happened.

Patrick didn't support Jean's protests overtly, but he didn't make her justify her involvement. Then, one spring night, he took her into the garden and told her that the "administration [is] discussing ways to shut [women] up." He asked her to skip the march the following week, but Jean argued that they weren't going to cut out women's tongues or something ridiculous like that. He begged, and Jean agreed. She passed the warning on to Dr. Claudia, Lin, and her other female friends. They all insisted it was impossible. But in retrospect, nobody in Jean's circle realized how supportive most of the U.S. was of the president. Jean wonders if Lorenzo might have a plane ticket or a passport for her as she pulls into her driveway. There's an ambulance in the Kings' drive.

Jean begins to realize there are limits to how much she can subvert the status quo while keeping herself and Sonia safe. Steven already reported Julia for having consensual premarital sex, so there's no telling what he'd do if he were to catch his mother and sister were speaking freely at home. This passage also contains a dire warning that it is, perhaps, naïve or inappropriate to trust fully in government institutions, like the Supreme Court, to work as expected. As Jean is discovering in this dystopian alternate future, such institutions can't protect her against a corrupt government that thinks it's above the law.



Patrick's character becomes a bit more complex here. Of course he wants to protect his wife if he believes she might get hurt at a protest, but Jean also seems to take it as a sign of his weakness and acceptance of the status quo that he just asked her to stay home and stay safe rather than doing something to protect women's rights more broadly.



CHAPTER 45

Olivia King isn't the first mother who has tried to take her own life after seeing her child taken away. Jean sends Sonia inside as the EMTs appear with the stretcher. Olivia's left hand is charred, and her wrist is just exposed bone. There's smoke coming from the Kings' front door. Patrick comes outside to catch Jean before she falls. Inside, he pours her a drink and can barely bring himself to say that Olivia recorded "I'm sorry, Julia" on a Dictaphone, set it to repeat, and set it out of reach. Losing his composure, Patrick says that "[w]e're doing everything we can. But when did it get so fucking bad?"

Here, Jean reveals that the Pure Movement is causing problems and even deaths, even among those who once supported it wholeheartedly. This suggests, first, that a mother's love for her children trumps loyalty to a movement. Moreover, the fact that the Pure Movement continues to arrest women who break the rules further underscores the movement's lack of care for women—the government neither cares about the women it arrests, nor the families who suffer when their female family members are taken away.



Hearing a sob in the living room, Jean finds Steven watching the ambulance drive away. With prodding, Steven says that when Julia's shaming was shown on TV, the teacher told the boys that they had to watch out for girls like her, as they'd drag the boys to hell. The teacher told his students that it's okay to use slurs and insults against people like Julia, and he had the boys shout slurs at the TV. Then, the teacher handed out a page full of slurs and asked students to write letters to Julia using as many as possible. Steven did it, but he notes that "Evil triumphs when good men do nothing." Jean nods.

Steven implies that he's not actually on board with the Pure Movement anymore, after seeing what happened to Julia. Jean's "punishment" of making Steven go to school to watch Julia's shaming worked. Now, it seems Steven has turned himself around and is willing to acknowledge that he's been complicit in a sort of "evil." It's now up to him and others with power to resist—though he must do so by hiding in plain sight, as when he writes the awful letter to Julia to blend in with his peers.



CHAPTER 46

Dinner feels almost normal—except Patrick is drunk, Steven has barely eaten, and Jean is exhausted. She puts Patrick and then Sonia to bed. She checks on Sam, Leo, and Steven—who's in his room to "tune out"—and then goes to break into the safe next to the bed where Patrick keeps his keys. He insists it's because of his security clearance, but Jean knows that all men lock their keys away from their wives now. After finally fishing out the keys from the safe that Patrick forgot to lock all the way, Jean spends an hour digging through his office. She finds nothing, though the top secret **envelope** from earlier is missing. Locking Patrick's office, Jean sneaks outside to the mailbox. The top secret envelope is in it.

Jean continues to see Patrick as an adversary, and someone complicit in her subjugation, as she shares with readers that all men now have keys that their wives cannot access. Jean's willingness to snoop through Patrick's office (and then break into the mailbox) points to a shift in her character. She's no longer just working for herself and her family. Now, she believes it's her responsibility to get to the bottom of whatever the government is trying to do—and stop it, if she can.



CHAPTER 47

Jean tries to imagine what will happen to her if she's caught stealing. Will they execute her? She decides to read what's in the **envelope** anyway, so she sneaks past the outdoor cameras and into the bathroom off the kitchen. The documents are divided by team, and the header page for each team lists its goal. The White team's goal is to "Develop, test, and mass-produce anti-Wernicke serum"; the Gold team's goal is to "Develop, test, and mass produce Wernicke serum," and the Red team is to "Explore water solubility of Wernicke serum." The project began in November, seven months ago. As Jean puts the documents back in, she hears Patrick coming. He buys her food poisoning excuse, though he asks if she's pregnant. Once he returns to bed, Jean puts the envelope back in the mailbox and drops Patrick's keys near his nightstand.

The contents of the envelope confirm Jean's suspicions: the government has been working on this project for months, and she, Lin, and Lorenzo are only a fraction of the people involved in it. The project itself seems extremely sinister, given that one team is creating a Wernicke serum—not an anti-Wernicke serum—and then another is exploring that serum's water solubility. However, Jean's focus returns to more immediate concerns when Patrick nearly discovers her snooping and her pregnancy, reminding her and readers that she can't escape her growing list of problems.



CHAPTER 48

Jean has a nightmare that people are taking her children away. She finally wakes up on Saturday morning to Patrick, Leo, Sam, and Sonia bringing her coffee and a bagel with a candle in it—it's her 44th birthday today. Steven is still asleep. Realizing she only has 50 minutes to get to work, Jean heads for the bathroom to pour out her coffee and shower. Patrick interrupts her: Steven has left to look for Julia. To Jean's shock, she feels very in love with Patrick, though she insists she can't have sex now. Patrick goes to get his keys, buying Jean's lie that he just doesn't remember the handle coming off last night because he's drunk. Once Jean is showered and dressed, she joins Patrick in his office. He shows her a clip of Reverend Carl shaming Julia and announcing that she'll be going to South Dakota.

Jean's dream reflects one of her deepest fears: that because she doesn't adhere to the government's rules for how women should act and behave, she won't be able to continue to parent her children. In other words, she knows she can work and be a mother and knows she'd like to do both, but doing so in this context is inappropriate and puts her and her children in danger. Steven's disappearance points more fully to his redemption; he now understands his responsibility to stand up for Julia and other women like her.



CHAPTER 49

Jean doesn't notice the idling government car until it's too late. She's already in her car by the time she puts it together that Patrick is working for the resistance, and Del is their courier. She's helpless to do anything as Del removes the **manila envelope**—and as Poe knocks Del out with a stun gun and as two other men drag Del into the car. However, Poe doesn't go to arrest Patrick. Jean considers driving to the farm to warn Sharon, but she reasons it'll be better to show up to work on time.

Suddenly, Jean realizes that Patrick isn't her enemy. Rather, Patrick has been doing the exact same thing Steven did in class the other day: he looks like he supports the status quo, but really, he's working to take down the Pure Movement and the current government. Taking his example, Jean decides to show up to work like nothing is wrong so as to not draw attention to herself and her family.



As Jean drives, she considers the “typos” she found in the red and gold packets in the envelope. She also thinks it's fishy that Project Wernicke is a classified project, when her team's project is national news. Morgan catches Jean as soon as she's through security. He scolds her for being late and threatens to report her, but Jean abandons him in the elevator. Lin isn't in yet, so Jean and Lorenzo turn on the sink and wash their hands so they can chat. Jean shares that she suspects there's no typo on the Gold team's goals: the Gold team is supposed to reverse-engineer a serum to cause Wernicke's aphasia, while the Red team is figuring out how to put that serum in the water supply. She also tells him about Del and the underground resistance, which the government seems to have discovered.

Jean finally puts it together that the government is trying to come up with a way to silence women without counters, by giving them a water-soluble serum that will scramble their language. Going through the water supply, though, raises even bigger questions about whether women are the sole targets of this project—or whether the government is planning to silence vast swaths of the population, or even other countries. Lin's absence is suspicious, given how essential her knowledge and skills are to the project.



CHAPTER 50

As Jean and Lorenzo prep two groups of mice for injections, Jean thinks back to the winter day that Olivia came over to watch Jackie on TV at Jean's house. Olivia had said that someone "should shut that woman up [...] permanently," and that's exactly what's going to happen. They'll probably start with the women in the camps, then Del (after interrogating him and threatening his family), and then Patrick. They'll poison people with Jean's work. Without Patrick, Jean won't be able to care for her children; there's no telling if Steven will come back. Jean imagines herself, old and unable to communicate. Lorenzo pulls Jean off the floor, where she's fallen and started to cry. They begin injecting the mice, and Jean thinks that the mice have names like Jackie, Lin, and Jean.

Once again, Jean suggests that she (and others) should've seen this coming long ago, and her own inaction over the last few decades has allowed the government to gain so much power that it can feasibly plan to poison half the population. Jean also recognizes, seemingly for the first time, how vulnerable women are in her current society: although she's currently an exception, as a rule, women in this society aren't allowed to work. Thus, it'll fall to Steven to support Jean and his siblings—if he returns at all. Finally, Jean suggests the mice are named after herself and her friends because she fully understands that what she's doing isn't theoretical: it's actually going to harm women and people she cares about.



CHAPTER 51

Jean and Lorenzo are planning to meet at their cottage in Maryland, so they leave work separately and take different routes. As she drives, Jean thinks of how the Pure Movement reworked the workforce when they took control, relegating the "unworthy" to unskilled labor and hiring top male graduates for white-collar jobs. She also cries about Steven's departure and vows to have Morgan send a vial of the cure to Mamma in Italy. Jean finally pulls in at the shack. After they have sex twice, Lorenzo tells Jean he can get her out of the country. He hands her an Italian passport for a woman named Grazia Rossi—his deceased wife. Jean insists she can't leave, but Lorenzo asks what they'll do if the baby's a girl.

Alone in her car, Jean lets all her emotions out. With Lorenzo, Jean again finds herself caught between what she wants personally, and what she feels she must do as a wife and mother. She doesn't feel she can just leave with Lorenzo because she has children here. And Sonia, Jean knows, will suffer if she stays in the U.S. and has her counter put back on. But Jean knows that she also has a responsibility to protect her baby, who, if it's female, will also be in danger. Thus, what might've been a messy and emotional drama under normal circumstances suddenly becomes an impossible and dangerous choice. And for Jean, there are no good options.



CHAPTER 52

Jean asks how long she has to make a choice, wondering which daughter to save. They discuss stalling the project, and Jean privately remembers a time when she and Jackie went on a Mexican beach vacation and managed to extend their stay by a few days. They still had to come back to the real world, though—the good times always end. Jean admits to Lorenzo that she wondered if Reverend Carl would reverse-engineer her serum. Though Lorenzo assures Jean it isn't her fault, Jean knows it is: she didn't protest with Jackie, or vote, 20 years ago.

Jean's memory of the beach trip suggests she understands that everything will have to end eventually—stalling the project won't actually do them any good in the long run. Lorenzo suggests that it's not appropriate or correct for Jean to take all the blame for Reverend Carl's deadly plans. But Jean insists that the blame lies squarely with her and other women like her who weren't politically engaged when they still could be.



CHAPTER 53

Jean and Lorenzo shower and discuss what to do. Jean is all for breaking into the other labs, but Lorenzo insists they'll just be caught and imprisoned. He insists that he and Jean leave the country, now—and since one of Jean's kids is his, he should get a say on where she goes. Jean agrees that she'll decide after her test next week: if it's a girl, she'll go, and she'll stay if it's a boy. As they drive separately back to the lab, Jean prays that nobody will take Sonia from her or inject her with a serum. She also prays the baby is a boy.

Lorenzo may be more principled than Patrick seems to be, but his suggestion that he should have some sway over where Jean goes suggests that he's still susceptible to using the power the current political system gives him, as a man, over the women in his life. And Jean, in contrast, doesn't get to make choices at all.



CHAPTER 54

According to the soldiers at security, Lin hasn't come to work today. Jean asks to see Morgan, and a young soldier named Sergeant Petroski escorts her. In the elevator, she asks if he went to college, what he majored in, and if he learned to fire his gun in his classes. He's a psychology major who didn't learn to shoot in school—and Jean notices his bottom lip quiver. He's afraid. He looks like a boy who made a bad choice. Perhaps, like Steven, he'll come around. But as the elevator stops, Petroski blinks three times at Jean.

The three blinks suggest that Sergeant Petroski, like Del, is part of the resistance, or is at least sympathetic to the idea that women should have rights and agency. Jean, notably, has more hope for the future after seeing Steven run away to rescue Julia. His actions show her that it is possible for men, particularly young men, to unlearn what the Pure Movement has taught them and to rediscover their capacity for compassion and respect.



Petroski knocks on Morgan's door and Jean enters. He asks for an update, while Jean asks where Lin is. Morgan doesn't answer; instead, he asks Jean to schedule her first human trial for tomorrow. Jean realizes Morgan wants something—she does too—so she agrees. She asks if it's possible to send a vial of the serum to Italy for Mamma, but Morgan points out that the U.S.'s relationship with Europe is “not good” right now. He also refuses to let Jean or Lorenzo take it. Jean asks again about Lin, and though Morgan insists he doesn't know where she is, Jean can tell he's lying.

Perhaps unsurprisingly, Morgan (and the government) are uninterested in European scientists possibly getting their hands on Jean's serum—this isn't about Jean's family, but rather about world politics. Lin's disappearance is both mysterious and foreboding, especially given that Jean earlier implied that Lin is a lesbian. That is, Lin's sexuality puts her at increased risk of being arrested.



CHAPTER 55

In the elevator, Jean thinks of what will happen if Europeans suddenly can't communicate—the continent will be “a languageless chaos, ripe to be taken over.” Sergeant Petroski leaves Jean and returns to his post to search men, likely from the Gold or Red teams, coming to work. Jean continues to the basement, where the mouse test is complete: one cage of mice is dead. They now know which neuroprotein to use and which is toxic. Jean writes “Bioweapon” and shows it to Lorenzo before burning the paper. She notes that injecting lots of people would take time, but spiking the water supply is easy.

Jean suspects that the government plans to use the serum that causes Wernicke's aphasia to poison, and then invade, Europe, thereby beginning a crusade for world domination.



Lorenzo calls Morgan down to view the results of the mice trial while Jean puts the dead mice in the freezer for Lin to examine later. Lorenzo notes that Lin was going to meet Isabel Gerber, her former fiancée, for dinner last night. Jean hopes Lin was careful. As Lorenzo asks about Jean's test on Monday, Jean knows she'll have to make a choice: stay here and watch everything get worse, or watch from Europe—and watch Europe “crumble to its knees.”

Interestingly, despite Jean's belief that she should be trying to do something to help, this passage expresses immense pessimism. As she sees it, the world is going to burn either way—her only choice is whether to watch the disaster unfold from the U.S. or Italy. This perhaps reflects her overwhelm, given all the far more meaningful choices she can't make about her situation.



CHAPTER 56

Jean gets home around seven to the kids playing three board games at once (Patrick told them Steven is with a friend). Patrick hands Jean a beer and invites her outside. As far from the house as they can get, Jean lies that she wanted to call Papà, but Patrick knows she didn't call anyone in his office the other night. Patrick shares that last September, he saw a man executed. His name was Jimbo, a junior scientist who was always blinking three times. He'd always leave in the afternoon and return with a lighter briefcase. A week before his execution, he approached Patrick and asked if Patrick was “pure.” Jimbo left a name and number for Patrick and said to call if he wanted to. It was Del's number.

Finally, Patrick comes clean with Jean about his involvement with the resistance movement. Notably, he begins his story by bringing up Jimbo's execution—driving home the high stakes of getting involved in acts of direct resistance. This makes it clear to Jean and to readers that Jean has misread her husband and his goals. His seeming “weakness” and complicity was actually a calculated strategy to blend in, allowing him to carry out important resistance work without getting caught. And Jean, because of her snooping and distrust of her husband, has perhaps put Patrick in danger.



Patrick continues that they'll shoot Del. When they shot Jimbo, they put men on their team on buses headed for Fort Meade for a team-building exercise, and then Thomas shot him. This, Patrick explains, is why he didn't tell Jean anything—“when” they come for him, it's better if she knows nothing. When Jean asks what will happen to Steven if he's found, Patrick puts his head in his hands.

Additionally, Patrick didn't tell Jean about his involvement out of a desire to protect her and their children. She and Patrick, this shows, chose to work in secret for the exact same reasons: they both want to protect the family they've built, even if their marriage is, in many ways, crumbling.



CHAPTER 57

Shockingly, Jean feels in love with Patrick tonight. After they put Sonia, Sam, and Leo to bed, Patrick tells Jean to get out of the country. Jean considers telling Patrick everything, but she doesn't have to: she realizes he knows about her affair, and he tells her to go with Lorenzo and take Sonia. They discuss what will happen, even if she leaves, when the government spikes the world's water supply. Jean imagines Morgan injecting her with the serum and what life might look like in Italy. But then, thinking of Jackie, Jean asks Patrick what he'd do to “get rid of all of them.” He says he'd do anything, even kill—though both he and Jean know the truth: “All [they] need to do is take away their voices.”

Now that Jean and Patrick have been communicating (mostly) openly about their goals and resistance efforts, their relationship has improved and even feels like love again. It also motivates Jean to reject the idea of running away and absolving herself of any responsibility to fix things. Now, she and Patrick conspire to save the world by, it seems, coming up with a way to incapacitate the top government officials who are most directly responsible for subjugating women.



CHAPTER 58

Jean fishes out the file she hid from Morgan, and Patrick flips through Lorenzo's notes. On the back of the fourth page, he notices something Jean never has: a poem in Italian that Lorenzo wrote to Jean. Patrick doesn't speak Italian, but he knows enough to understand it's a love poem. Jean doesn't answer when Patrick asks if the feelings are mutual, but Patrick seems to understand they are anyway. Jean leaves to make coffee and give Patrick a minute alone. When she returns, Patrick has good news: Jean's serum will be easy to reverse engineer, and if they don't care about negative side effects, it's already water soluble. Patrick asks if Lorenzo can have it ready by Monday morning: that's the next all-staff meeting for Project Wernicke. Even Reverend Carl will be there. Jean agrees.

Patrick doesn't insist on hashing out Jean's affair or her reasons for entering into it in the first place. This may simply reflect his focus on the problem at hand or his own need to think things over first, but it may also suggest that he perhaps understands how his and Jean's relationship has begun to disintegrate over the last few years, particularly as the Pure Movement took over. Coming up with the Monday morning deadline creates tension since it seems that it's necessary to take down the government as soon as possible in order to save the world.



CHAPTER 59

Jean sleeps for a few hours before heading to the lab with Patrick's notes hidden in a powder compact. She palms the notes to Lorenzo and goes to set up for Mrs. Ray. Lin isn't at work, and Jean knows she won't come in again. In the lab, Jean puts a rabbit in a cage so Mrs. Ray has something nice to look at. Morgan walks in as Jean opens the fridge to get the anti-aphasia serum out. Yesterday, there were six labeled tubes of the serum that killed the mice—but now, there's only one. Trying to flatter Morgan, Jean asks how connected he is and if he's been in the White House. He proudly shares that he's attending the meeting on Monday before sticking a finger into the rabbit's cage. The rabbit bites him.

The rabbit symbolically suggests Jean's (and women's more broadly) powerlessness. Under the Pure Movement, they've all been put in figurative cages. But when the rabbit bites Morgan, it also speaks to Jean's increasing willingness to fight back and harm those who have hurt her. The missing vials are extremely concerning, especially since the missing vials are the ones that can kill. Jean clearly suspects Morgan, though whether her suspicions are correct remains to be seen.



Jean is bandaging Morgan's finger when Lorenzo walks in and remarks that the rabbits haven't been tested for rabies. Morgan hurries out. Lorenzo whispers to Jean that he can follow Patrick's notes, but he'll need to work overnight and tomorrow. Feigning awe and admiration, Jean shares that Morgan will attend the meeting on Monday, as will Patrick. As they try to access the biochem lab, though, they discover that their keycards don't work.

Morgan's inclusion in the Monday meeting means that Jean, Lorenzo, and Patrick can incapacitate him at the same time as the rest of the government. The locked biochem lab indicates that their plan is running into issues, however: it won't be easy to look like they're doing what they've been told, now that they no longer have unfettered access to the various labs.



CHAPTER 60

Jean immediately gets on the intercom and tells Morgan she needs access to the biochem lab. He insists that isn't necessary or possible: another team is propagating the serum, so if Mrs. Ray's trial works, Jean and Lorenzo are done working. He says Mrs. Ray is on her way down. Jean hangs up. Last night, Patrick explained to Jean that it would be possible to reverse engineer Jean's serum without Lorenzo's notes, though it'd be slower. In a whisper, Jean asks Lorenzo if she has the only copy of the notes. He races away.

At this point, Jean's main goal is ensuring that if Morgan is going to try to reverse-engineer the deadly serum, he at least has to work for it. Thus, it's extremely important that Lorenzo guard his notes carefully. Jean and Lorenzo also now face a time limit as to how long they can remain in the labs, seeming as though they're doing what they're supposed to while actually working to subvert Morgan.



CHAPTER 61

Lin has left detailed notes describing two methods of administering the injection: through a drilled hole directly into the brain, and intravenously. Jean is relieved that Mrs. Ray will arrive with a catheter already placed in her arm, though she wonders if she's actually doing the right thing by restoring Mrs. Ray's ability to communicate. Jean also considers Lorenzo's offer—but how horrible would she be if she left her four children here? Still, she knows she's also a terrible parent to stay and condemn her possible future daughter to a life with a **counter**.

Morgan, an orderly, and Mrs. Ray enter the lab. Jean first met Mrs. Ray years ago, when the old woman approached Jean with plans to turn Jean's garden into something beautiful. The first Black president had just been elected. She had a stroke just before that president ceded power to the next one. When Jean greets Mrs. Ray, Mrs. Ray responds with nonsense. Lorenzo takes over filling the syringe from Jean, and the orderly wheels Mrs. Ray into her room. Alone for a moment, Lorenzo shakes his head—the Gold team has the serum and formulas. He says he has tickets, and when Morgan asks for what, Lorenzo says they're for the symphony.

As Jean and Lorenzo approach Mrs. Ray, they share a look. If the serum works, their president will essentially bring about the end of the world. Supply chains, stock markets, and transit will disappear. Anyone who survives will be left trying to live off the land. Does Reverend Carl understand this? Lorenzo hands Jean the syringe, and she injects the liquid. Ten minutes later, Mrs. Ray looks at the rabbit and says she used to have a bunch of rabbits as a child.

Jean continues to mull over the fact that she really doesn't have good choices to make, if she has choices to make at all. Morgan is going to force her to test the serum on Mrs. Ray, and he'll certainly find someone else to do it if Jean won't. As Jean considers her lack of choices, she descends into hopelessness and self-loathing, highlighting how her lack of choice keeps her from feeling any fulfillment—even from things that should make her happy, like discovering the cure for Wernicke's aphasia.



In this passage, Dalcher makes clear allusions to the real world: the first Black president is, no doubt, Barack Obama, and the "next one" is Donald Trump (President Myers is his analogue in the novel). By making these connections clear to the reader, Dalcher seems to suggest that what's happening in the novel might be far-fetched in some ways—but if people don't take Jean's lessons to heart, particularly about the importance of organizing, something along these lines could indeed happen in the real world.



Here, Jean suggests that without language, civilization as they know it will collapse in its entirety. Language is important not just because it gives people power to advocate for themselves, but also because it's essential for communities to function and thrive. And this is true at a small scale (like in neighborhoods) and on a bigger, global scale.



CHAPTER 62

Jean feels "like a god," but also like her life is ending. Morgan leaves, waving for the orderly to follow with Mrs. Ray. With his eyes, Lorenzo gestures toward the fridge—where six vials marked with an X now sit. Hoping Sergeant Petroski is still working, Jean grabs a vial and some rubber gloves, steps into the bathroom, and hides the vial in her vagina. When she comes out, Poe is in the lab. He pokes around for a few minutes and then escorts Jean and Lorenzo out of the lab, confiscating their key cards. They collect their laptops and belongings from their offices, and soldiers frisk Jean and Lorenzo at the door. Jean imagines them subjecting her to an invasive search and finding the vial, but they allow her to leave. Poe tells them to not come back.

Once again, Jean figures out how to weaponize her femininity and qualities (or in this case, body parts) that the Pure Movement associates with women. By hiding the vial in her vagina, she uses a part of her body that the Pure Movement suggests makes her inferior to, hopefully, bring about the Pure Movement's end. The vials' return is mysterious and suggests that Jean (and readers) aren't fully aware of just what's going on in this lab.



CHAPTER 63

After Jean calls Patrick on Lorenzo's phone, Lorenzo says he has to leave the country and slips Jean an envelope. It feels like it contains a passport and a phone. Jean, however, is more interested now in removing the vial and hiding it in one of Sonia's abandoned sippy cups. She's still sitting in her car when Morgan and an armed guard come out of the building, insisting that Jean needs to come back in. Lorenzo steps between Jean and the guard, but Morgan says he actually needs both of them. Jean slowly gets out of the car and, with Lorenzo, follows Morgan into the building and down to the sub-basement.

It's notable that while Poe showed Jean and Patrick out of the building, Morgan and an armed guard now force them back inside. This raises the possibility that Poe and Morgan aren't actually working for the same team. And the fact that they're being forced back in to continue work of some sort means that Jean gets to put off her choice of whether to follow Lorenzo out of the country for a while longer.



CHAPTER 64

The sub-basement lab is filled with about 50 young male scientists, all busy at work. They pass through this lab and into a room lined with cages. These ones contain primates. Jean immediately notices that cages labeled as bonobos, gorillas, and orangutans are empty. Half the cages labeled as chimps are empty. Clearly, this team is working through all the great apes, saving humans for last. As she makes this realization, Jean's knees buckle, and she falls against a male chimp's cage. She remembers Lin warning her that Hannibal Lecter was tame compared to a chimp. The chimp yanks on Jean's hair and grips her wrist while Jean remembers the mutilated face of a woman who got too close to a chimp. A shot rings out.

This lab is chilling, both because of the busy scientists—their work isn't done, and they're presumably continuing Jean's work to carry out the more nefarious parts of Project Wernicke—and because of the primate lab animals. The chimps are close relatives of humans, which makes them common subjects for trials like this, but Jean also recognizes that Morgan likely sees some humans (likely women) as little better than chimps. Still, as terrifying as the chimp's attack on Jean is, it also points to women's power to fight back and regain their rights.



CHAPTER 65

As Jean opens her eyes, Morgan is yelling at the soldier for killing a valuable animal. Lorenzo tells Morgan to find a first aid kit and call a doctor, insulting him. Morgan finds the kit, but he refuses to call for help. Lorenzo bandages Jean's bleeding face and helps her up. Morgan then leads Jean and Lorenzo into another lab, this one filled with more men busy working and soldiers patrolling. He announces that this is Jean and Lorenzo's new team, and a man brings over two binders labeled "top secret." As Jean flips through the binders, Morgan fires the soldier who shot the chimp, and Jean and Lorenzo realize that the scientists in this lab are hostages: they're all married.

Morgan shows his true colors become here: at least on some level, he would've rather the chimp injured or killed Jean than have had the soldier kill the animal. However, on the other hand, the fact that the soldier killed the chimp without thinking about whether this was the choice his boss would've wanted points to the soldier's humanity—he clearly sees Jean's life as more valuable than the chimp's, because she's human. There's hope, in other words, that Jean may have more allies in this lab than she realizes.



Morgan says he needs a serum that will induce Wernicke's aphasia by tomorrow. Jean refuses, but Morgan just laughs. He asks a soldier to take Jean and Lorenzo to Room One and show them what's in there. Jean is terrified of finding snakes or her own children inside. Instead, there are three people in there, one of whom calls Jean "Jeanie"—a name nobody has used for 20 years. The woman receives a shock for this.

Jean and Lorenzo understandably don't want to bring about the end of civilization as they know it. And so, Morgan turns to blackmail, illustrating his heartlessness and hunger for power.



CHAPTER 66

Jean pulls away from Lorenzo and takes Jackie in her arms, begging Jackie not to speak and cause herself more suffering. Jackie is a shell of her former self, and she sobs. Jean hears Morgan enter and a gun cock behind her. Suddenly, though, she realizes that Morgan doesn't have Lorenzo's notes—this is why he's demanding a formula by tomorrow. She doesn't know who took the notes. Jean looks to Lin and Isabel Gerber, the other two prisoners. She wishes she still had the vial of poison to force down Morgan's throat. Morgan asks if Jean and Lorenzo will cooperate, or if he needs to send Lin, Isabel, or Jackie to Fort Meade for execution.

Suddenly, Jean is struck by how important time is. Twenty years ago, she chose to spend her time studying instead of protesting. She has a day before she finds out if her baby is a boy or a girl, and 18 hours until the Monday-morning meeting. She'll spend forever wishing she could go back in time and not slap Steven. Morgan passes out pink booklets to Jackie, Lin, and Isabel and reminds them to read their manifestos, chuckling that Jean will get her own "**bracelet**" put back on soon. Jackie throws her booklet at Morgan's face. Jean promises Jackie she'll do all she can and follows Lorenzo and Morgan into the lab.

Seeing a strong, independent, and outspoken woman like Jackie brought so low by the current government is a galvanizing moment for Jean. She realizes she has a responsibility to help Jackie, Lin, Isabel, and other women who are going to suffer if Jean continues to do nothing. Helpfully, though, she puts it together that someone other than Morgan took Lorenzo's notes, offering hope that they'll be able to stall for a while longer.



Jean thinks about time here because she realizes that she's wasted her time up to this point. Yes, her research has been important, but as she faces the end of civilization and her own subjugation, she realizes she should've been protesting, like Jackie. Morgan's choice to refer to the counter as a "bracelet" again highlights how language can be used to shape reality: calling it a "bracelet" suggests it's a good (and conventionally feminine) thing, when it's actually a torture device.



CHAPTER 67

There's a giant television on one wall, the volume turned up. Reverend Carl appears on the TV to announce "unfortunate news": he has found a "lost sheep." He motions for someone to join him. Jean is shocked that the person is Steven. Jean is so angry, she doesn't hear the rest of what Reverend Carl says. She sees the word **counter** on Steven's arm. Remembering Jackie and Patrick, Jean realizes she'd do anything to "stay free," even kill. Jean barely recognizes herself as she thinks this, but she likes who she's becoming.

While referring to believers as "sheep" or a congregation as a "flock" is common in Christian circles, it takes on a decidedly sinister feeling here. Referring to someone as a "sheep" can also suggest that they're easily controlled—which Steven was, until he chose to reject the Pure Movement and try to rescue Julia. Reverend Carl is upset about the fact that someone has defected, and Jean realizes that he'd like to make an example of Steven, too.



CHAPTER 68

At 5:00 p.m., Morgan announces that nobody gets to go home. Once he leaves, Jean tells Lorenzo that they need to use Petroski, and Lorenzo reveals that his work is done. Jean checks his calculations: what Lorenzo has come up with will render a person mute in a few seconds. Lorenzo can formulate it in a few hours, and they both agree that they should test it on Morgan first. The only problem, Lorenzo notes, is that it could be fatal if injected or ingested: it needs to be injected straight into the brain. The thought makes Jean sick.

Morgan is a satisfying test subject because Jean and Lorenzo hate him so much. Attempting to test their serum on him is a way of asserting their power: they're better scientists, and they're morally better people than Morgan.



Lorenzo suggests they tour the room and get a sense of what kind of qualifications the other scientists have; Jean can also call Patrick about the car. Jean approaches Sergeant Petroski, who asks Jean to write him a message for Patrick; he has to make the call for Jean. Jean's note reminds Patrick that Sonia will be distraught without her sippy cup. She and Petroski blink three times at each other, and then Petroski shares that he'll be here overnight. When Jean asks, he also shares that he's been married two years and has a one-year-old daughter. He asks if he can ask Jean a question.

Petroski explains that he's the oldest of four. He describes watching his youngest brother begin to understand and then express himself, first with single words and eventually in full sentences. Then, Petroski says he saw a documentary about a girl, Genie, who was locked up for 12 years and not spoken to. She never learned to speak and ended up institutionalized. He asks if it's true that kids have "some kinda clock" in them, and if they never get to speak, will they ever learn? What will happen to his daughter if she never gets to speak? Jean adds a few more things to her note to Patrick, and Petroski asks if they can just ride out "this Pure thing." Jean lies and says that kids only have until three or four until their brains "click off." Petroski goes pale, and Jean resumes her walk to check out ID badges.

Calling Patrick about the car is really calling Patrick about the vial of poison in Sonia's sippy cup; Jean is still planning to help Patrick poison government officials at the Monday morning meeting. Petroski confirms again that he's not sold on the Pure Movement and would like to help Jean. Noting again that he has a wife and daughter suggests that, like Del, having women in his life who are important to him motivates his desire to resist the Pure Movement.



Genie was rescued in 1970 at the age of 13, and hers is considered one of the most severe cases of social isolation, child abuse, and neglect. She did acquire some ability to communicate, but as this conversation suggests, children do have a "critical period" in which they have the best chance of learning to speak. Note that Jean lies to Petroski; most children can still learn to speak effectively if they do so before they enter puberty. Her lie, though, ensures that Petroski is willing to help her in order to save his daughter and preserve her ability to learn to speak, something he realizes is an essential skill that allows a person to participate in society.



CHAPTER 69

When Jean and Lorenzo reunite back at their workstations, they've discovered that most of the scientists here are PhDs—experts capable of coming up with "a brain-scrambling neurotoxin" overnight. Jean shares that Petroski is an ally; he's strong, in uniform, and is terrified for his daughter. She also notes that all the scientists are exhausted, and soon, they'll have the lab to themselves. Lorenzo tells Jean to rest for a few hours and, while she's at it, gives her an iPad to read up on brain science, anatomy, and trepanning—he's busy and so she'll have to perform the procedure on the chimp, unless they're okay with starting on Morgan and possibly killing him.

Jean loudly asks a soldier for an escort to the dorms, and Petroski calls her over. He says he called Patrick, and he asks if he can do anything else for her. Jean tells him exactly what to do.

Jean and Lorenzo essentially realize here that the other scientists outnumber them, but they also have the advantage as they haven't put in as grueling of a day as the other scientists have. In insisting that Jean perform the procedure on the chimp (or on Morgan), Lorenzo asks Jean to essentially confirm that she is indeed willing to kill in order to stay free, testing her resolve.



Thanks to Petroski's love and concern for his daughter, he's more than willing to help Jean and Lorenzo. It means his daughter will be able to grow up and, hopefully, live a normal life in which she has agency.



CHAPTER 70

In the dorms, Jean eats a sandwich and studies articles and diagrams, preparing herself to drill into the chimp's brain and inject it with the serum. She's squeamish and unsure, but thinking of Jackie, Lin, and Isabel, she tells herself to get over it. Finally, she falls asleep and wakes up some time later to Petroski, who's ready to take her to Lorenzo. She reminds Petroski that Morgan entered the lab with a headache a little while ago. When they reach the lab, Jean finds it empty—Lorenzo and Petroski cleared it out by making a smoke bomb. Lorenzo is waiting for Jean at a doorway. Inside the room, Morgan and a female chimp are on stretchers, heavily sedated. Trying to keep from vomiting, Jean turns on the drill—but she finds she can't do it.

Jean knows that she has to do what she can to save not only herself and her friends, but humanity worldwide. That she isn't able to complete the task raises questions not necessarily about her commitment, but about whether she can put aside her squeamishness to do what she believes is the right thing.



CHAPTER 71

Jean realizes she isn't capable of killing. She tells Lorenzo to get Petroski: they need the keys to break Lin out so she can do this. Lin appears five minutes later and, using sign language (which Lorenzo translates), asks Jean to assist her. Lin drills into the chimp's skull and injects a vial into its brain. She completes the procedure in five minutes. Both the chimp and Morgan are stirring now.

Because Jean can communicate, she can use that ability to put together a team capable of accomplishing this task.



CHAPTER 72

Jean is terrified. Lin hurriedly signs that the chimp will be fully awake in less than two minutes. Jean and Lorenzo begin to quickly wheel the chimp back toward her cage, and Jean tells wide-eyed Jackie and Isabel to lock themselves in a closet for their safety. Jean screams for Petroski, who arrives and pulls his gun just as they reach the cage. As the chimp fully wakes up, Jean and Lorenzo haul her into her cage and slam the door shut. This still leaves Morgan, who can only leave the lab by passing through the animal cages. Lorenzo runs back toward Morgan. Jean follows a minute later—and realizes that Morgan, Lorenzo, and a syringe of poison are all in the same place.

Things get intense as the chimp and Morgan begin to wake up. Both pose threats to the novel's heroes, but with the chimp returned to her cage, Morgan—and his connections, hunger for power, and cruelty—is the far more dangerous of the two.



CHAPTER 73

Morgan holds the needle to Lorenzo's neck and insults Jean as she walks in. Jackie appears behind Jean with Petroski's keys. Jean tells Morgan to be sensible: people will ask questions if an esteemed Italian scientist can mysteriously no longer speak intelligibly. If Petroski shoots Lorenzo, Morgan can claim self-defense or an accident. Morgan finally shouts for Petroski. When Petroski enters the room, Morgan tells him to shoot Lorenzo. Jean asks if the safety is off—and Jackie leaps onto Petroski. Jean grabs the gun and shoots Morgan.

Morgan's fault, and what causes his eventual demise, is that he consistently underestimates his female colleagues. Because he sees Jean as weak due to her being a woman, it never occurs to him that she might actually be able to do something to hurt or kill him (especially since she was unsuccessful at injecting the serum into his brain already).



CHAPTER 74

Both Jean and Morgan fall to the floor. Morgan lies in a puddle of blood. Lorenzo helps Jean up, and as Jackie, Lin, Isabel, and Petroski move Morgan's body, he explains that Jean killed Morgan. Everyone helps clean up the blood, then they scrub their hands, put on lab coats to hide the blood on their clothes, and Jean asks Petroski to get them past security. Only then does Jean notice Poe. Poe, taking Petroski's gun, tells everyone to come with him. He ushers them into the elevator.

Poe's appearance is concerning at first, but he also doesn't say anything that gives away his true motives here. Poe thus illustrates how he uses his silence—the lack of language—to gain power and keep others guessing at his loyalties and motives.



CHAPTER 75

Steven is in the elevator, and he collapses in Jean's arms. Poe gently pries them apart and instructs everyone to stay silent. He hands fake **counters** to Petroski, Jean, and Lorenzo and says that if everyone cooperates, he can get them out. When they get out of the building, everyone must get in the van. The elevator doors open, and one of the soldiers says that Morgan doesn't want the scientists to leave. Poe hands over an envelope with the presidential seal on it, and the soldier reads that Poe's prisoners are all headed for Fort Meade. The soldiers whisper about the prisoners' fate, and Jean remembers Steven paraphrasing the idea that evil flourishes when good men do nothing.

The fake counters are an immediate indicator that Poe is, perhaps, not the evil henchman Jean and Lorenzo have thought he was for the last few days. His gentleness with Jean and Steven seems to corroborate this. As Jean listens to the soldiers, she suggests that one thing that enabled the Pure Movement to come to power was the fact that even good men, who could still speak, didn't stand up and express discontent with what was happening.



Jean follows everyone else into the dark van, and the doors close behind her. Then, lights come on, revealing Del and Sharon. Jean nearly falls into Sharon's arms, and Sharon removes Jackie's **counter**. Once it's off, Jackie curses that this has been worse than a meditation retreat she once attended.

Jackie's first words seem extremely on-brand for her, suggesting that the counter has in no way broken her spirit. In this sense, then, the Pure Movement is failing: women have not yet given in to their subjugation.



CHAPTER 76

During the drive to the Rays' farm, Del and Sharon explain everything. Poe has been working undercover, Del's arrest was staged, and they rescued Steven from the floor below the labs. Poe stops the van and comes to help everyone out. Lorenzo lifts Jean down, and as Jean falls against him, Patrick calls her name. Jean approaches Patrick, and she, Steven, and Patrick hug. After checking on Leo, Sam, and Sonia sleeping in the living room, Jean falls asleep next to Sonia while Poe shares how Jean will escape.

Jean and Patrick's marriage may be on the rocks right now, but they both still care immensely about the family they've built together. And thanks to Patrick's involvement with the resistance, they now have a bigger community to help their family get to safety.



CHAPTER 77

In the morning, Patrick kisses his family goodbye. Jean spends the morning imagining what's happening at the meeting. She imagines Patrick at the meeting, poisoning the water, champagne, and coffee. President Myers, Bobby Myers (magically cured of his aphasia, if he was ever ill), Reverend Carl, Thomas, and several other officials are present. There will be 13 men present—Patrick will be like Judas at the Last Supper. Jean finds this funny. Patrick plans to keep some of the vial for himself, just in case. Jean can't imagine her husband dying.

Jean's delight in reimagining the Last Supper highlights the irony of the officials' downfall. They have used religion to justify the subjugation of half the population, and now they themselves will become victims of that same religion, at least symbolically.



CHAPTER 78

Jean accompanies the children to the barn, where Sonia introduces her brothers to the horses. Jean calls her doctor's office and cancels her appointment to find out the baby's sex. Then, Sonia asks if she can be a vet. Jean notes that becoming a vet will require a lot of school, but Steven notes that Jean got through a doctorate. To hide her tears, Jean heads back toward the house. She joins Lorenzo, and they discuss that according to Poe, Jean has to leave the country and leave her children here. It's too dangerous for her to stay. Just then, Poe skids into the driveway in Patrick's car. He gets out and screams for Lin about not being able to stop the bleeding. Jean opens the car's rear door.

As a way of apologizing to his mom for the way he's treated her over the past year, Steven essentially affirms that women are capable of doing other things besides being housewives and mothers. This not only helps Jean to feel like her children are proud of her for all the things she's doing besides being their mother, but it also reinforces for Sonia that she can be whatever she wants to be, if she chooses. This passage ends on a cliffhanger, while suggesting that Jean's worst nightmare has come true, and Patrick has died.



CHAPTER 79

Jean had planned for a quiet funeral for Patrick, but lots of people, including Olivia, Evan, and Julia, have come to the Rays' farm. Thanks to Patrick, things are changing. It's been a few days, but Jean still isn't safe. Del, Sharon, and Jackie are going to stay and help rebuild the country, but Jackie encourages Jean to go, putting a hand on Jean's belly. Lorenzo leads Jean back to the house, and Jean tells her children to pack.

Everyone seems to be coming out of a trance since Patrick took down the government, as evidenced by Pure Movement supporter Evan showing up to his neighbor's funeral. Though Jean seems interested in helping the U.S. heal, Jackie suggests that there's a time and a place to prioritize politics, and now is the time for Jean to heal herself and prioritize her growing family.



Jean insisted that Chris Poe tell her exactly what happened. Ironically, Morgan caused Patrick's death: Patrick came running out of the room, yelling about a lockdown and Morgan's memo. The guards on the White House roof shot Patrick, and Patrick smiled as the bullet hit him.

Patrick's heroic death reinforces the novel's insistence that effective protest and resistance can be almost invisible—Patrick wouldn't have gotten to this point had he not looked like he supported the president for the last year.



CHAPTER 80

Jean, her kids, and Lorenzo spent two months in Canada while their passports processed. Now they're in southern Italy, and thanks to the notes Poe stole from Lorenzo's office, Lorenzo is going to have the serum ready for Mamma by the weekend. Lorenzo is good with the kids, and even Steven has come around to accepting him. Soon after they all left the U.S., the media started to function again. Women marched silently until their **counters** were removed, and Jackie leads every march. Jackie plans to visit Italy soon.

Jean isn't ready to return yet, even though the secretary of health and human services became the president—he's vowed to never let the country return to what it recently was. Jackie has been writing excitedly about the midterm elections and female representation in government. Jean is financially supporting Jackie's causes and plans to enter politics when she returns, but she's not ready yet. She loves being in Italy, watching Sonia learn Italian and Italian women speak with their whole bodies.

Everything is coming together for Jean and Lorenzo. They can now conduct their relationship openly, and most importantly for Jean, she's made the choice to do so—something that finally allows her to find happiness. In the U.S., women now have their voices back, and Jean implies that they're no longer willing to sit back and allow the government to control them.



Jean has changed: she realizes the importance of getting involved with politics and advocating for her rights. But she also now is able to make the choice about how, and when, to get involved—and by choosing to wait until later, she's able to enjoy this idyllic period in Italy. With her ability to make choices returned to her, she's finally found contentment.





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